

THE QUIET GIRL

from 2B



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The Quiet Girl from 2B
A Forbidden Neighbor Romance

JJ Vale

PMI

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Contents

[Title Page](#)
[Copyright](#)
[Chapter 1](#)
[Chapter 2](#)
[Chapter 3](#)
[Chapter 4](#)
[Chapter 5](#)
[Chapter 6](#)
[Chapter 7](#)
[Chapter 8](#)
[Chapter 9](#)
[Chapter 10](#)
[Chapter 11](#)
[Chapter 12](#)
[Chapter 13](#)
[Chapter 14](#)

Chapter 1

I pressed opened my new trashy novel.

It looked like a good one, the kind that promised to carry me somewhere far, far away. I tucked my feet under me on the couch and pulled the throw blanket up to my chest and cracked the spine gently, the way you do with a book you already know you're going to love.

The apartment was quiet. The radiator clicked and hummed. Outside, the last light of autumn faded behind the buildings across the street. The streetlamp flickered on in that hesitant, apologetic way it always did.

I read the first paragraph and the world as I knew it fell away. I disappeared into the story, and became someone else entirely, living a whole other life, for just a little while, anyway.

The first time I went upstairs was because of a little package.

That's what I keep coming back to when I try to trace how it all started. I stood in our hallway holding a small brown cardboard box with someone else's name on it. The delivery people were always mixing things up, dropping items where ever was convenient, and I'd found this one sitting outside the door when I came home from work on a regular afternoon.

D. Moreau. 3B.

We were in 2B. Callum and I had been living together for eight months by then, long enough that the place felt like our own home sweet home, despite the water stains on the ceiling and the way the kitchen faucet screamed when you turned it too high.

We'd hung pictures and bought a secondhand couch. I'd arranged all my books in alphabetical order on the shelf Callum built, and on weekends we made French press coffee and read the news on our laptops with our legs tangled together under the blankets. It was the kind of life I'd always wanted, quiet and soft and safe.

I should have left the package outside 3B and walked away. That's what Callum would have done. He would have set it by the door, knocked once, and gone back downstairs without waiting. He was efficient and considerate like that, and he would have been done with it.

But not me. I knocked and I waited. I told myself I wanted to make sure it got to its destination safely.

I'd seen the man from 3B before, passing him on the stairs or catching glimpses of him coming in late at night when I happened to be staring out my windows. He was tall with broad shoulders and the kind of build that suggested he used his body for some kind of hard physical work. He had a face that looked like it had been in a few fights too, and hadn't minded too much, either. He wore his dark hair in short twists that perfectly suited him.

Callum moved like he was trying not to inconvenience anyone. This man moved like inconvenience was someone else's problem.

The door opened, and there he stood, shirtless, sweatpants riding low on his hips, bare feet. He held a half-eaten apple in his hand, a grin spreading across his face when he found me standing there.

"Hey," he said in no big rush or even in any state of surprise. He leaned into his doorframe.

I held up the box and waved it at him. "This was left downstairs, which I believe is yours?"

He looked at the package then back at me. His eyes were dark and warm. They held mine with an ease that made my face get hot. He wasn't staring me down or trying to intimidate me. He was just taking me in like I was interesting, like he had all the time in the world to find out why.

He "considered his apple and snapped off a bite. You're the girl from 2B," he said.

"I am."

"The quiet one." He grinned at me.

I didn't know what to say to that. I wasn't even sure if it was an insult or just an observation, but his grin got a little wider like he was enjoying my confusion.

He took the box from my hands and his fingers brushed mine. I felt it in my chest, a small sharp thing, like a hook catching on fabric.

"I'm Deke," he said. "You want to come in? I got coffee."

I should have said no. I had a frozen pizza waiting in the freezer and a book I was halfway through and a boyfriend who would be home soon. There was no reason to say yes, and I knew it even as I opened my mouth.

"I guess," I said. Brave girl, I thought. "For a bit."

"For a bit," he repeated as though it amused him to try on my words.

His apartment smelled like cigarette smoke and sandalwood. The layout was the same as ours, one floor up, but it looked like a different planet. Where our place was neat and organized with everything in its place, his was chaos. Clothes were draped over chairs, a guitar leaned against the wall, empty bottles lined up on the windowsill like a collection, posters were taped to the walls, their corners curling. The afternoon light came through his window in golden slants and caught the dust floating in the air.

"Coffee's in the kitchen," he said, and he walked ahead of me without looking back like he knew I would follow.

I followed.

I walked into his kitchen where he was already pouring coffee into two mismatched mugs. One had a chip on the rim and the other a faded logo from some bar I'd never heard of, of course. He handed me the one without the chip.

"Milk's in the fridge if you want it," he said. "Sugar's somewhere."

He waved his hand at the counter which was cluttered with dishes and boxes and a pair of sunglasses and a wrench. I didn't ask about the wrench. I took the coffee black because I didn't want to go digging through his fridge. I stood there holding the warm mug in both hands while he leaned against the counter and watched me.

"You can sit down," he said. "I don't charge."

He was still grinning that way and there was something in the way he said that that made me think he was leaving the rest of some sentence unspoken. I sat down at his small kitchen table which wobbled when I put my elbows on it. He didn't sit but remained where he was, leaning back and looking at me with that same easy, slightly amused interest.

"So what do you do, quiet girl from 2B?"

"I work at the library," I said. "Downtown branch."

"A librarian." He said it like he was tasting the word and he nodded as though that answered a lot of questions. "That fits."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"Nothing bad." He took a sip of his coffee. "You got that look, though. Like you're always thinking about something deep, like somethings in your head that's more interesting than what's in front of you."

I didn't know what to say to that, so I looked down at my coffee. The surface was dark and still and I could see a faint reflection of myself in it.

"What do you do?" I asked, because the silence felt heavy and I needed to fill it.

"Little of this, little of that." He shrugged. "I do some personal training. Pick up bartending shifts when I feel like it. I'm not what you'd call career-oriented."

"It sounds nice," I said like I meant it.

He raised an eyebrow. "Yeah?"

"I just mean it sounds free. Like you can do whatever you want."

"I do do whatever I want," he said. "That's the idea, right?"

He pushed off from the counter and walked past me toward the living room. I turned in my chair to watch him go, and he looked back over his shoulder.

"Come on," he said. "I want to show you something."

I should have finished my coffee and made an excuse and gone back downstairs to my frozen pizza and my book and my quiet life. But I got up and followed him, the kitchen chair scraping the floor as I pushed it back.

The living room was dim because he had the blinds still half-closed, and it took my eyes a moment to adjust. He walked over to the window and pulled a cord. The blinds rattled up and the late afternoon light came flooding in. The window faced west and the sun was low enough that it turned everything gold. The dust in the air looked like glitter.

"Best view in the building," he said. "Your place faces the building, right?"

"How do you know which way my place faces?"

He only grinned at me.

I walked over to the window and stood next to him. He was right about the view. We looked out over the back of the building and there was a little courtyard I'd never seen before, overgrown with weeds and wild grass, and beyond that, the rooftops of the neighborhood stretching out toward the horizon. The sky was pink and orange and I could see birds circling in the distance.

"I didn't know it was like that here," I said.

"Most people don't come up to the third floor."

I could feel the heat of him next to me. He was close enough that if I shifted my weight I would brush against his arm.. I stayed very still looking out at the view. My heart was beating fast.

"I should go," I said.

"Okay quiet girl."

He didn't argue or try to convince me to stay. He just said it like it was fine, like whatever I decided was good, but somehow that made it harder to leave. I turned and walked toward the door and he followed me at a distance.

"Thanks for the coffee," I said.

"Thanks for the package." He leaned against the doorframe as I stepped into the hall. "Come back sometime, quiet girl. I'll show you the roof."

I walked down the stairs to 2B. My legs felt strange, like they weren't quite mine. I let myself into our apartment and closed the door behind me and stood there in the dim entryway for a long moment. The place smelled like the lavender candle I'd lit that morning, and everything was where I'd left it. My book was on the arm of the couch with my bookmark sticking out. The throw blanket was folded over the cushions. The light on the coffee maker blinked green.

I went to the kitchen and I put the frozen pizza in the oven and I set the timer. I sat on the couch and I opened my book and I stared at the page without reading a single word.

I'll show you the roof.

I thought about that for the rest of the night. I thought about it when Callum came home and kissed my forehead and asked me how my day was. I thought about it when we ate dinner together and watched TV with my feet in his lap, him rubbing me vacantly. I thought about it when we went to bed and he fell asleep with his arm around me, too, breathing slow and steady against my neck.

Chapter 2

I told myself I wasn't going back up. There was no reason to go up there. He was just a neighbor and it was just a coffee, and none of it meant anything nor should it.

But four days later, I went back.

I told myself it was because I was curious about the roof. But I waited until Callum left for work in the morning, and then I waited another hour just to be sure, before I climbed the stairs to the third floor. I stood outside 3B with my hand raised to knock and I almost turned back and went downstairs.

But I knocked.

He opened the door, and now he was wearing jeans and a white t-shirt, but his feet were still bare. He looked down at me and that grin started at the corner of his mouth again and spread slow across his face.

"Quiet girl," he said. "I was wondering when you'd show up."

"You said you'd show me the roof."

"I did say that."

He stepped back and held the door open, and I walked inside. His apartment smelled the same as before, smoke and sandalwood and that warm thing underneath. He closed the door behind me.

"Roof's this way," he said.

He led me through the living room and down a short hallway. At the end of the hallway there was a door with a deadbolt and he slid the bolt back and pushed it open. Metal stairs led up into bright white sky.

I climbed up after him and when I stepped out onto the roof the wind hit my face and I had to squint against the sun. The roof was flat and covered in gravel with a low wall running around the edge. There were two lawn chairs set up near the middle, faded and rusted, and a milk crate between them that was being used as a table. A few crushed beer cans sat on top of it.

"Welcome to my office," he said.

I walked to the edge and looked out at the city. From up there I could see everything, the water towers and the church steeples and the highway in the

distance and cars moving like toys. The wind blew my hair across my face and I pushed it back behind my ear.

"It's amazing," I said.

"I come up here when I can't sleep." He walked up beside me and stood with his hands in his pockets, looking out at the same view. "Four in the morning, there's nobody in the world but me and the pigeons up here."

"That sounds lonely."

"Nah." He glanced at me sideways. "Lonely is being in a room full of people who don't see you. This is just being alone. Big difference."

I didn't know what to say to that. I stood there looking out at the city and I was aware of how close he was, and how far away everything else seemed. My job at the library, my boyfriend, my apartment one floor down, the life I'd built over the past eight months. It all felt very small from up there.

"You want to sit?" he asked.

We sat in the lawn chairs and he pulled two beers from somewhere, a cooler I hadn't noticed tucked behind the milk crate. He popped the caps off with his keychain and handed me one. It was cold and sweating in my hand.

"I shouldn't," I said. "It's ten in the morning."

"Yeah?"

I looked at him. He was watching me with that same easy grin. His eyes were warm and patient. He wasn't pushing. But he was just waiting to see what I would do.

I took a sip of the beer. It was cheap and a little skunky, and it tasted like rebellion.

He laughed. It was a good laugh, deep and surprised like I'd done something that pleased him.

"There she is," he said.

"There who is?"

"I don't even know yet." He took a sip of his own beer. "But I got a feeling she's more interesting than just a quiet girl who works at the library."

I stayed on that roof for two hours. We drank our beers and he told me about the time he got arrested for drag racing in a stolen car when he was nineteen, and I told him about the summer I spent at my grandmother's house in the country when I was twelve, reading books in the hayloft while the barn cats slept in the sun. I don't know why I told him that. I never told

anyone that story. But he listened and when I was finished he said, "Sounds like you've always needed a place to hide out."

I thought about that all the way home. I thought about it while I showered and changed my clothes and sprayed perfume on my wrists so I wouldn't smell like beer and cigarette smoke. I thought about it while I ate lunch and went to work and shelved books in the quiet stacks of the library.

A place to hide out.

Three days later, I told myself it would be the last time. I told myself I was just curious, just bored, just killing time. I climbed those stairs to the third floor and I knocked on his door and he opened it with that grin, and something inside me loosened a little bit more.

He never bothered to lock his door. He was playing guitar when I came in and didn't stop when he saw me. He just nodded toward the couch and I sat down and listened while he played. His fingers moved over the strings like they knew the way without looking, and the music was low and bluesy and it filled up all the space in the room. When he finished, I realized I'd been holding my breath.

"You're good," I said.

"I'm okay." He set the guitar aside. "You play anything?"

"I took piano lessons when I was a kid. I don't remember much of it."

"You got nice hands."

He was looking at my hands and I looked down at them too. I noticed they were trembling a little and I pressed them flat against my thighs.

"You nervous?" he asked.

"No."

"Liar."

He said it gently like it was a joke we were both in on. He got up from his chair and walked over to the couch. He sat down next to me, not touching, but close enough to. I could feel the heat of him through the thin fabric of my top.

"You don't have to be nervous," he said. "I'm not gonna do anything you don't want me to do."

"I know that."

"Good." He leaned back against the cushions and stretched his arm out along the back of the couch. His fingertips were an inch from my shoulder. "Chillax."

I tried to. I tried to make my body go soft and easy the way his was. But every part of me was aware of that inch of space between his fingers and my shoulder, and I couldn't think about anything else.

"Can I ask you something?" he said.

"Yes."

"Why do you keep coming back up here?"

I had an answer, but it wasn't one I could say out loud. I sat there with my hands pressed flat against my thighs and I felt the silence stretch between us.

"You don't have to say," he said. "I'm just a curious cat."

"I don't know," I said. "I guess I like it up here?"

"What do you like about it?"

I thought about his question. I thought about his apartment with its chaos and its warmth, the smell of smoke and sandalwood, the way the light came through the windows in the afternoon. I thought about the roof and the view of the city and the taste of cheap beer at ten in the morning. I thought about how I felt when I was there, like I was someone who could do things without thinking about the consequences.

"It feels like a different world," I said.

He smiled at me. It wasn't a grin this time, it was something softer.

"Yeah," he said. "I know what you mean."

His fingers moved now and they brushed against my shoulder. I didn't pull away. I sat very still and felt the warmth of his touch through my top. My heart was pounding so hard I was sure he could hear it.

"Tiff," he said. It was the first time he'd used my name. I'd told it to him on the roof, and hearing it now in his voice made something twist in my stomach. "What do you want?"

I couldn't answer. I sat there looking at him, his dark eyes and his easy smile and the way he was waiting for me, patient and unhurried, like he could wait forever if that's what it took.

I stood up. The movement was sudden and graceless and I bumped the coffee table with my knee.

"I have to go," I said.

He didn't stand up and he didn't try to stop me. He just watched me with that soft smile as I grabbed my bag and walked to the door.

"Tiff."

I stopped with my hand on the doorknob.

"You know where to find me," he said.

I walked down the stairs to 2B. My hands were shaking so bad I could barely get my key in the lock. I went inside and closed the door and leaned against it with my eyes shut.

I told myself that was it. I told myself I was done, that I'd gotten too close to something dangerous, that I needed to stop before I did something I couldn't take back.

Chapter 3

When I got back to our apartment, I showered and changed clothes and sprayed perfume on my wrists. I opened all the windows to let the air circulate. Then I sat on the couch with my book and waited.

Callum came home at six-thirty.

"Hey," he said. "How was your day?"

"Good. I went for a walk."

"Yeah? Where'd you go?"

"Just around the neighborhood. I found a little park I'd never noticed before."

"That's cool." He loosened his shirt and sat down next to me. "We should go together sometime. I could use more fresh air."

"Sure," I said. "That would be nice."

He turned on the TV and found a documentary about penguins. We watched it together while we ate leftover pasta from the night before. His feet were on the coffee table and mine were tucked under my legs, and when I laughed at something one of the penguins did, he looked over at me and smiled.

"I like it when you laugh," he said.

I smiled back at him.

The third time I went up, I told Callum I was going to run errands.

"You need anything from the store?" I asked him. It was a Saturday morning, and he was sitting at the kitchen table with his laptop open, working on something for his job even though it was the weekend.

"Maybe some of those crackers I like? The ones with the rosemary?"

"Sure."

I grabbed my bag and keys and I walked out the front door. I climbed the stairs to the third floor and I knocked on 3B.

Deke opened the door in sweatpants and nothing else. His chest was bare with a thin gold chain around his neck.

"It's quiet girl," he said.

"I can't stay long. I told him I was running errands."

He stepped back and let me in. "Then you better come in quick."

His apartment was messier than before. There were dishes piled in the sink and clothes on the floor and a pizza box open on the coffee table with two slices left inside. He walked over and closed the box and tossed it onto a chair.

"Sorry about the mess," he said.

"I don't care about the mess."

He looked at me, and something in his face shifted. His grin was still there, but there was something else underneath it now.

"You want coffee?"

"No."

"Beer?"

"It's eleven in the morning."

"So?"

The apartment was quiet except for the sound of traffic outside and the hum of his refrigerator.

"Okay," I said. "One beer."

He got two bottles from the fridge and opened them and handed one to me. We stood in his kitchen, not sitting, and we drank our beers. He leaned against the counter and I leaned against the opposite counter and we faced each other across the narrow space.

"You're different today," he said.

"Different how?" I drank back a big gulp, felt it fizz down my throat. Liked it.

"I don't know. More here like?"

I didn't know what that meant, but I felt it too. I felt more here, more present, more awake than I had been in a long time.

"Can we go up to the roof?" I asked.

"We can do whatever you want."

We went out the door and climbed the metal stairs and stepped out into the bright Saturday morning. The sun was warm and the sky was blue and cloudless, and the city spread out beneath us in all directions. I walked to the edge and put my hands on the low wall and breathed in deep.

He came up behind me. He stood close and I could feel the heat of his body against my back even though he wasn't touching me.

"You ever wonder what it would be like?" he asked.

"What what would be like?"

"To just go. Leave everything behind and start over somewhere else. New city. New name. New life."

I kept my eyes on the horizon. A plane was drawing a white line across the sky.

"Maybe sometimes?" I said.

"I did it once. Packed a bag and got on a bus and didn't tell anyone where I was going. Ended up in New Orleans for six months. Played guitar on street corners for tips. Slept on people's couches. It was the best time of my life."

"Why'd you leave?"

"I don't know. I just woke up one day and I was done. That's how it works for me. I do something until I'm done, and then I do something else."

He was right behind me now and I could feel his breath on my neck. I didn't turn around. I kept my hands on the wall and my eyes on the sky.

"You're not like that," he said. "You're the other kind. The kind that stays. The kind that builds up things and keeps them. But there's another part of you that wants to run. I can see it."

"You don't know me."

"I know what I see."

His hand came up and touched my hair. He moved it to the side, away from my neck. His fingers brushed against my skin and I felt it run down my spine like electricity.

I turned around. We were very close and his eyes were dark and warm and he was looking at me with that same patient expression, like he could wait forever if that's what it took.

"I have to go," I said. "I'm just running errands, supposedly."

"So go run errands."

He stepped back and gave me room. I walked past him toward the stairs, but my whole body was buzzing.

"Quiet girl," he said.

I stopped.

"You forgot your beer."

I looked back. The bottle was sitting on the ledge where I'd left it, still half full, sweating in the sun.

"It's your beer," I said.

I walked down the stairs and through his apartment and out the door. I went down to the second floor and past my own apartment and out into the

street. I walked to the grocery store four blocks away and I bought rosemary crackers and a carton of milk and a package of chicken breasts for dinner. I walked home with the grocery bag in my arms and I let myself into the apartment.

Callum was still at the kitchen table with his laptop.

"You were gone a while," he said.

"There was a line at the deli counter."

"Find the crackers?"

I pulled them out of the bag and tossed them to him, and he caught them with one hand.

"Perfect," he said. "Thanks, Tiff."

I put the groceries away and started preparing the chicken for dinner. My hands were steady and my face was calm, and no one looking at me would have seen anything different at all.

Chapter 4

I went up in the middle of a Tuesday afternoon when Callum was at work and I had the day off. I told myself I was going to spend it reading and cleaning the apartment and maybe going for a walk in the park.

Instead I put on a cute sundress and white sneakers and walked up to the third floor and knocked on his door.

He opened it with a phone pressed to his ear. He held up one finger and stepped back, and I walked into his apartment while he finished his conversation.

"Yeah, man, I'll be there. Friday at eight. Got it. Later."

He hung up and tossed the phone onto the couch.

"You look nice," he said.

"It's just a dress."

"It's a nice dress."

He was looking at me the way he always looked at me, but there was something different today, something more direct. He didn't pretend to be interested in something else. I walked around as though looking at the view, but letting him take me all in.

"I was going to play some records," he said. "You want to listen to some records?"

He had a turntable set up in the corner of his living room, an old one with big silver knobs and a wooden case and a milk crate full of vinyl records sat next to it. He knelt down and flipped through them, and I came over and looked over his shoulder.

"You pick," he said.

I didn't know most of the names. I pulled out one with a blue cover and a woman's face on it.

"Very good choice," he said. "Billie"

He put the record on and set the needle down, and the speakers crackled and then music filled the room. It was old soul, a woman's voice low and rich, singing about loss and longing. He stood up and we stood close together, listening.

"Dance with me," he said.

"I don't dance."

"Everyone dances."

He held out his hand and I stared at it. His palm was wide and his fingers were long and there was a callus on the pad of his thumb from playing guitar.

I took his hand.

He pulled me close, one hand in mine and the other coming to rest light on my lower back. We swayed more than danced, moving slow through the afternoon light that came through his windows. The music washed over us and I let myself lean into him, let myself feel his chest against my face and his hand warm through the thin fabric of my dress.

"See?" he said. His voice was close to my ear. "You dance just fine."

"This isn't dancing. This is just standing and moving a little."

"That's all dancing is."

The song ended and another one began, something slower and sadder. We kept moving and his hand slid a little lower on my back, settling into the curve of my spine. I could feel his heartbeat against my cheek.

"Tiff," he said.

I looked up. His face was very close and his lips were slightly parted. His eyes were soft.

"I should go," I said.

He didn't answer, he just looked at me. His hand remained on my back and mine was still in his and we were standing so close that I could feel his breath on my lips.

I stepped back and his hands fell away.

"I'll see you later," I said quietly.

"Okay."

I grabbed my bag and walked to the door and I didn't look back. I walked down the stairs and into my apartment and I stood in the entryway with my back against the door and my heart pounding in my chest.

I went into the bedroom and I changed out of the sundress and put on jeans and a t-shirt. I put the sundress in the back of the closet where neither of us would see it. I went into the kitchen and started cleaning, wiping down the counters and scrubbing the sink and organizing the spice rack.

When Callum came home, dinner was ready and the apartment was spotless.

"Wow," he said, looking around. "You've been busy."

"I had the day off. I wanted to make myself useful."

"Well, it looks great." He kissed my cheek. "And something smells amazing. What's for dinner?"

"Chicken piccata."

"Avery good choice."

We sat down at the table and I watched him eat. He told me about his day at work and the coworker who was giving him a hard time and the staff meeting that had run an hour over.

"But enough about me," he said. "What did you do all day? Besides clean the entire apartment?"

"Just relaxed. Read a little. Nothing exciting."

"Sounds perfect." He reached across the table and squeezed my hand. "You deserve a quiet day."

I squeezed back and smiled at him, and I thought I heard somewhere above us a record still playing.

The next time, we kissed.

It happened fast and slow at the same time. I was sitting on his couch looking at a book he'd handed me, some collection of photographs from the 1970s, and he sat down next to me and leaned over to point at something on the page. His shoulder pressed against mine and his face was close and I turned my head to say something and he was right there.

He paused. His eyes moved down to my lips and then back up to my eyes. He was giving me time to pull away.

But I didn't pull away.

His lips touched mine, soft at first, questioning. I didn't move. I didn't breathe. His hand came up and cupped the side of my face, his thumb resting against my cheekbone, and he kissed me again, deeper this time.

My eyes closed. The book slid off my lap and hit the floor. I felt his other hand settle on my waist, and I felt myself leaning into him. His mouth was warm and he tasted like coffee and something sweet.

He pulled back but his hand was still on my face.

"You good?" he asked.

I nodded. I couldn't speak.

He smiled with that slow smile I was starting to know so well. He leaned in again, and this time I kissed him back.

His hand slid from my waist to my hip and then to the small of my back, pulling me closer. I put my hands on his chest where I could feel his heart

beating fast under my palms. His lips moved from my mouth to my jaw and to my neck, and I tilted my head back and let him.

Then I heard a sound from outside, a car horn. Something broke, and I pulled back.

"I have to go," I said.

"Okay, quiet girl."

He let me go and didn't try to hold me back. I stood up and grabbed my bag and walked to the door on legs that didn't feel like mine.

"Tiff."

I stopped with my hand on the knob.

"Anytime, okay?"

I didn't answer. I opened the door and walked out and went down the stairs.

When I got back to our apartment, I went straight to the bathroom and looked at myself in the mirror. My lips were slightly swollen. My cheeks were flushed. My hair was messy where his hands had been pushing in it.

I turned on the cold water and splashed it on my face. I fixed my hair. I put on lip balm and pressed my lips together. I practiced smiling in the mirror until I looked normal.

Callum came home two hours later.

"Hey," he said. "Sorry I'm late. Grabbed a beer with the guys."

"It's fine. I made soup."

"Perfect. I'm starving."

We sat at the table and ate soup and bread, and he told me about his day. I nodded and smiled and asked questions in all the right places.

"You're quiet tonight," he said.

"Am I?"

"Want me to make tea?"

"That's nice."

He got up and went to the kitchen. I could hear him filling the kettle and getting out mugs. He was humming something under his breath.

I sat at the table and waited for my tea, touching my fingers to my lips before I realized I was doing that, and stopped and checked if he noticed.

The next morning I woke up early and made coffee and sat at the kitchen table while Callum showered. Steam drifted out from around the half-open bathroom door and I could hear him singing, something off-key and happy.

I wrapped my hands around my mug and stared at the wall blankly. What horrible person was I?

He came out with a towel around his waist, his hair wet and sticking up in all directions.

"You're up early," he said.

"Couldn't sleep."

He kissed the top of my head on his way to the bedroom. "Take it easy today."

I listened to him getting dressed, the sound of drawers opening and closing, the clink of his belt buckle. He came back out in his work clothes, tucking in his shirt.

"I might be late tonight, too", he said. "We've got some deadline, boss is stressed."

"That's fine. I'm sure I can keep bus," I said, and I immediately winced.

He grabbed his bag and his keys and kissed me on the mouth this time, quick and familiar.

"Love you," he said.

"You too."

Chapter 5

The door closed behind him. I sat at the table and listened to his footsteps going down the stairs, and then the front door of the building closing, and then nothing. I leaned over and waited to see his car leave the building driveway.

The apartment was quiet. The sink made a soft gurgling sound. I washed my mug and put it in the drying rack and made our bed and fluffed our pillows. I took a shower and washed my hair and shaved my legs without thinking about why. I stood in front of my closet for a long time, looking at my clothes.

I put on jeans and a gray sweater. Nothing special, nothing that would make anyone think anything.

I sat on the couch and picked up my book and read the same paragraph four times without absorbing a word of it. The clock on the wall ticked. Outside, I could hear traffic and birds and the distant sound of someone's radio.

I put the book down, picked it up again, read another paragraph.

At eleven-thirty, I got up and walked to the door. I stood there with my hand on the knob before I went back to the couch. I picked up my phone and scrolled through nothing and put it down.

At noon, I made a sandwich and ate half of it standing over the kitchen counter. I wrapped the other half in plastic and put it in the fridge.

At twelve-fifteen, I put on some shoes. I told myself I was going out for a walk. I told myself I needed fresh air, that I'd been cooped up too long, that it was a nice day and it would be good to get outside. I grabbed my keys and my phone and I walked out the door.

And then I climbed the stairs to the third floor and knocked on 3B.

He opened the door in a tank top and basketball shorts. His skin was damp like he'd been working out. A towel was draped around his neck.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey."

He stepped back and I walked in. The apartment smelled like sweat and there was heavy music playing from somewhere, something with a bass that I could feel in my chest.

"Give me five," he said. "I was in the middle of pushups."

"I can come back."

"Nah. Sit down. I'll be quick."

He disappeared into the bedroom and I heard water running. I stood in his living room and looked around. There were free weights stacked in the corner, a yoga mat rolled up against the wall, a jump rope hanging from a hook. The coffee table had been pushed aside to make room.

I sat on the couch. The cushions were worn and soft, and they smelled like him. I picked up a magazine from the stack on the floor. It was about motorcycles. I flipped through it without seeing the pages.

He came back out in fresh clothes, his face still damp from washing. He sat down on the other end of the couch, not too close, and stretched his arm along the back.

"So," he said.

"So."

"You came back."

"I came back."

He smiled, and there was something knowing in it, something that made my stomach flip.

"You want something to drink?" he asked.

"Water?"

He went to the kitchen. I heard the tap running, the clink of a glass. He came back and handed me the water and sat down again, a little closer this time.

"How you feeling, quiet girl?" he asked.

"What do you mean?"

"Yesterday. You left pretty quick."

I took a sip of water.

"I'm perfectly fine," I said.

"That's good."

He was looking at me, and I was looking at my water, and the music pulsed in the background, some song I didn't know, a woman's voice, low and breathy, singing words I couldn't make out.

"What is this?" I asked.

"What, the music?"

"Yeah."

"Erykah Badu. You don't know her?"

I shook my head.

"I can educate you." He got up and walked to the turntable. He lifted the needle and the room went quiet. He flipped through his crate of records and pulled one out. "This is where you can start."

He put the record on and the speakers crackled and then her voice filled the room, rich and strange, singing about being born underwater and learning to breathe.

"She's amazing," I said.

"Yeah, that she is."

He walked back to the couch. He didn't sit on the other end this time. He sat in the middle, close enough that his thigh was almost touching mine.

"Yesterday," he said.

"We don't have to talk about it."

"I know we don't have to, I want to."

I looked at him. He was leaning back against the cushions, relaxed, his eyes warm and steady on my face.

"What do you want to say?" I asked.

"Nothing. I want to know what you're feeling."

"I'm not feeling anything."

"Liar."

He said it soft, like before. Like it was a game we were playing.

"I shouldn't be here," I said.

"You just got here."

"Don't you think I know that?" I sat there with the glass of water in my hands, and the music played, and he just watched me.

"You're scared," he said.

"I'm not scared."

"Then why do you keep running away?"

I didn't have an answer. I looked down at my hands. The glass was sweating, droplets running down the sides and pooling on my fingers.

"You don't have to be scared of me," he said. "I'm not going to do anything you don't want me to do."

"I know that."

"So what are you scared of?"

I turned my head and looked right at him. He was close enough I could see the individual hairs in his eyebrows, the slight roughness of stubble on his jaw, the texture of his lips.

"Myself," I said.

He smiled. It was a slow smile.

"Yeah," he said. "That's it isn't it."

He reached over and took the glass from my hands and set it on the floor. Then he turned back to me and lifted his hand and touched my face, his fingers brushing along my jaw, tracing the line of it from my ear to my chin.

I closed my eyes instinctively.

His thumb moved to my lower lip. He touched it, light and gentle, exploring. I felt my lips part. I felt my breath catch.

"Look at me," he said softly.

I opened my eyes. He was right there, inches away. His hand was on my face.

"Tell me to stop and I'll stop," he said.

I didn't say anything.

He leaned in. His lips brushed against mine, barely touching, just the suggestion of a kiss. My hands were flat against my thighs and I could feel my heart pounding in my fingertips.

He pulled back a fraction. "You still good?"

"Yes."

He kissed me again, deeper this time. His hand slid from my face to the back of my neck, his fingers driving into my hair. I felt myself leaning into him, felt my hands come up off my thighs and find his chest. His shirt was thin and I could feel the warmth of his skin through the fabric, the steady beat of his heart.

His other hand came to my waist and pulled me closer. I shifted on the couch, turning toward him, and he guided me until I was in his lap. My knees were on the cushion beside his hip and my hands were on his shoulders and we were kissing like we had all the time in the world.

His mouth moved from my lips to my jaw to the spot just below my ear. I tilted my head back and felt his breath warm against my neck. His lips trailed down, soft and slow, and I heard myself make a sound I didn't recognize, soft and high.

His hands were on my hips now, his thumbs tracing circles through the fabric of my jeans. He kissed my collarbone just above the neckline of my sweater, and I felt my whole body shiver.

"Tiff," he said, his voice low against my skin.

I pulled back. My breathing was ragged and my heart was racing and I felt like I had a fever.

"I want to go," I said.

He let me go. He always let me go. He leaned back against the cushions and watched me as I climbed off his lap and stood there on unsteady legs.

"You going to come back?" he asked.

"I don't know."

He smiled. "You do know."

I grabbed my phone and keys and walked to the door and opened it and stepped out into the hall.

"Hey," he said.

I looked back.

"Take your time," he said. "I'm not going anywhere."

I went downstairs and back to our apartment. I locked the door behind me and went straight to the bathroom and turned on the shower as hot as I could stand it. I stripped off my clothes and stepped under the water and stood there with my eyes closed, letting it beat against my skin.

I could still feel his hands on my waist. I could still taste his lips on my lips.

I stood in the shower until the water turned me into a prune, and then I got out and dried off and put on my softest clothes and curled up on the couch with my book. I read the same page over and over. The words blurred together. My body was humming and would not settle down.

Callum came home at eight. He looked tired, his shirt loosened and his hair messed.

"Long day," he said.

"You want a glass of wine?"

"God, yes."

I poured two glasses of red and we sat on the couch together. He turned on a show we'd been watching, something about detectives, and I leaned against his shoulder and tried to focus on the show.

"You smell nice," he said.

"I took a shower."

"New soap?"

"Same soap."

He kissed my temple and turned back to the show. I watched the detectives find clues and interview suspects and piece together the truth,

and I thought about how easy it looked, how they just followed the evidence and everything fell into place, how they never lied to anyone or pretended to be something they weren't.

"You okay?" Callum asked. "You feel tense."

"I'm fine."

"Maybe you should see a doctor."

"It's just the weather. It always gets to me when it changes."

He rubbed my shoulder, his thumb working at a knot I hadn't realized was there.

"That feel good?" he asked.

"Yeah, sure."

"Come here."

He turned me around and put both hands on my shoulders and started working out the tension. He was good at this. He'd always been good at it. His hands were strong and steady and he knew exactly where to press.

I closed my eyes and let him work on me. I tried to clear my mind. I tried to think about nothing but his hands on my shoulders and the sound of the TV and the warmth of the wine in my stomach.

I tried not to think about door 3B.

A week went by I didn't go upstairs. I went to work and shelved books and helped patrons find what they were looking for. I came home and made dinner and watched TV with Callum. I went to bed early and woke up late and filled my days with errands and chores and reading.

I told myself it was over. Whatever it was, it was done. I told myself I had caught it in time, that nothing irreversible had happened, and that I could still walk away clean.

On Saturday, Callum suggested we go to the farmers market.

"It's supposed to be nice out," he said. "We could get some vegetables, walk around, maybe grab lunch somewhere."

"That sounds nice."

Chapter 6

We walked to the market together, his hand in mine. It was a warm day, sunny, the kind of spring weather that made everyone smile at strangers. We looked at tomatoes and asparagus and fresh bread. We bought a jar of honey from a woman with bees in her backyard. Callum made jokes and I laughed at them and we held hands and we looked, I'm sure, like any other happy couple enjoying their weekend.

On the way home, we passed a man playing guitar on the corner. He was older, with gray in his beard, and he was playing something bluesy and sad. Callum dropped a dollar in his case and the man nodded thanks without stopping the song.

"You ever wish you could play an instrument?" Callum asked.

"Sometimes."

"I took piano lessons as a kid. I don't remember any of it."

"Me too," I said.

We walked the rest of the way home in comfortable silence. Callum carried the bags and I carried the honey. We climbed the stairs to the second floor and I didn't even look up at the third. I kept my eyes forward, focused on our door, on our life.

Inside, we put away the groceries and Callum suggested we cook together. We made pasta with the vegetables we'd bought standing side by side at the stove, bumping hips and stealing tastes. It was nice. It was easy. It was everything good and wholesome.

That night, in bed, Callum reached for me.

"Come here," he said, and his voice was soft and low.

I went to him. He kissed me, slow and sweet, and his hands were gentle on my skin. I closed my eyes and let him touch me. I tried to be present. I tried to be there, in that moment, with him.

But somewhere in the back of my mind, I was thinking about different hands. Rougher hands. Hands that pulled instead of asked.

Afterward, Callum fell asleep with his arm across my waist. I lay in the dark and stared at the ceiling and listened to him breathe.

Monday, I had the early shift at the library. I shelved books until my arms ached and helped a teenager find resources for her research paper and answered the same question about the broke copier all day. When my shift ended at two, I walked out into the afternoon sun and started toward home.

I stopped at the coffee shop on the corner and bought a latte. I sat at a table by the window and watched people pass on the sidewalk. I checked my phone. I had a text from Callum: *Hope you had a good day. See you tonight. Love you.*

I texted back: *You too.*

I finished my latte and threw away the cup and walked the rest of the way home. I climbed the stairs to the second floor and stopped outside our door.

I could hear music faintly coming from above. That same song, the Erykah Badu one, Learning to breathe.

I stood there with my key in my hand. The music floated down through the ceiling. I could feel it in my chest, that heavy bass, that strange and beautiful voice.

I put my key in the lock turned it. The door opened but I didn't go in.

I closed the door and locked it again. I climbed the stairs to the third floor and raised my hand to knock on 3B.

Before I could, the door swung open.

Deke was standing there in jeans and a button-down shirt, like he was about to go out somewhere. He looked at me and that smile spread across his face, slow and warm.

"I was wondering when you'd come back," he said.

"I wasn't going to."

"But here you are."

"Here I am."

He stepped back and held the door open. I walked inside.

The apartment looked cleaner than before. He'd done the dishes and picked up the clothes and there was a candle burning on the coffee table, something that smelled like cedar and smoke. The record player was spinning and Erykah was singing and the late afternoon light came through the window in warm golden slants.

"You going somewhere?" I asked, nodding at his shirt.

"I was. Not anymore."

He closed the door behind me. I stood in the middle of his living room and didn't know what to do with my hands.

"You want to sit down?" he asked.

"I guess."

We sat on the couch but not at opposite ends this time. He sat in the middle and I sat next to him, close enough that our knees touched. The candle flickered and the music played and neither of us spoke.

"I tried to stay away," I said.

"I know."

"I'm not good at this."

"At what?"

"Whatever this is."

He turned to look at me. His eyes were soft, patient, waiting.

"It doesn't have to be anything," he said. "It can just be two people sitting on a couch listening to music." He grinned.

"Is that what this is?"

"It's whatever you want it to be."

I looked at him. He was so close, I could see the flecks of gold in his dark eyes, the way his lips curved when he smiled, the faint scar above his left eyebrow that I'd never noticed before.

"What happened there?" I asked, reaching up to touch it.

"Bar fight. Long time ago."

"Did you win?"

"Does it look like I lost?"

I laughed, and he laughed, and some of the tension broke. My hand was still near his face, hovering in the air between us. He reached up and took it and brought it to his lips and kissed my palm.

The touch was light, almost innocent, just his lips against the center of my hand. But I felt it everywhere. My breath caught and my skin flushed and I watched him watch me react.

He turned my hand over and kissed my wrist. I could feel his lips against my pulse point, and I knew he could feel how fast my heart was beating.

"Tiff," he said, his voice a murmur against my skin.

I didn't answer. I couldn't answer. I just watched as he kissed his way up my arm, pushing back the sleeve of my sweater, his lips trailing along the inside of my forearm. Each kiss was slow and deliberate. He was taking his time. He was letting me feel every single one.

When he reached the bend of my elbow, he stopped and looked up at me.

"Come here," he said.

I moved toward him. He guided me onto his lap, my knees sliding down either side of his hips, my hands coming down on his shoulders. His hands settled on my waist and he looked up at me with that warm, steady gaze.

He smiled and then he leaned up and kissed me.

This kiss was different from earlier. It was slower, deeper, more intense. His hands slid up my back and I felt myself arch into him. My fingers found the buttons of his shirt and I undid the top one without thinking, and then the second one, and then I stopped.

He pulled back. "You good?"

"I don't know what I'm doing."

"Yeah, you do."

He kissed me again, and his hands found the hem of my sweater and slid underneath. His palms were warm against my bare skin and I gasped into his mouth. He traced his fingers up my spine, slow and light, and I felt goosebumps rise in their wake.

I undid another button on his shirt. And another. I could see his chest now, the smooth brown skin, the definition of muscle, the thin gold chain resting in the hollow of his throat. I put my hand flat against his heart and felt it beating.

"You're shaking," he said.

"I know."

"We can stop."

"I don't want to stop."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he reached down and pulled my sweater over my head in one smooth motion.

The air was cool against my skin. I was wearing a plain white bra, nothing special, and I felt suddenly exposed. But he was looking at me like I was something precious, something rare, and the self-consciousness faded.

"You're so beautiful," he said.

I didn't know what to say, so I kissed him instead.

We stayed like that for a long time, kissing on his couch in the fading afternoon light. His hands explored my back and my sides and the curve of my waist. My hands traced the planes of his chest and the breadth of his shoulders. The music played on, one song bleeding into the next, and the candle burned lower, and the world outside ceased to exist.

At some point, he lifted me up and carried me to his bedroom. He laid me down on his unmade bed and stretched out beside me, and we kept kissing,

slow and deep. His hand traced down my side and came to rest on my hip, his thumb rubbing small circles on the bare skin above my jeans.

I looked at him. His face was close to mine on the pillow, his eyes dark and patient. He wasn't pushing. He was waiting. He was giving me all the time in the world.

I reached up and touched his face. I traced the line of his jaw, the curve of his cheekbone, the shape of his lips. He let me explore, let me take the time I needed.

"I want to stay longer," I said.

"Then stay."

I stayed until the light outside his window faded from gold to pink to purple to black. I stayed until my body was loose and warm and my mind was quiet for the first time in weeks. I stayed until I looked at the clock on his nightstand and saw that it was almost eight.

I shot up fast.

"I got to go."

He didn't try to stop me. He propped himself up on one elbow and watched as I found my sweater on the floor and pulled it on.

"I can't keep doing this."

"Doing what?"

I stopped with my sweater half on, one arm through and one arm out. I looked at him lying there in his rumpled bed, shirtless, smiling at me like he had no worries in the world.

"This," I said and I glared at him.

"Okay."

He didn't argue. He just said okay, and that was worse somehow, because it meant the choice was entirely mine.

I finished putting on my sweater and grabbed my phone. I had three texts from Callum. The first asked what I wanted for dinner. The second asked if I was okay. The third just said: *Getting worried. Where are you?*

I texted back: *Sorry, got caught up with a friend from work. On my way home now.*

I let myself out of Deke's apartment and went down the stairs. I stopped on the second floor landing and took a deep breath. I smoothed my hair, pulled down my sweater, practiced my smile.

Then I walked into the apartment and there was Callum, standing in the kitchen with his phone in his hand, looking relieved.

"There you are," he said. "I was starting to worry."

"I'm sorry. I should have texted sooner. I ran into Sarah from work and we got coffee and lost track of time."

"That's nice. You haven't seen her in a while."

"Yeah. It was good to catch up."

He came over and kissed me, and I kissed him back, and I wondered if he could taste someone else on my lips. But he just smiled and said, "I ordered food. Should be here in twenty minutes."

"Perfect," I said. "I'm starving."

We ate on the couch and watched TV and talked about nothing important. I laughed at his jokes and asked about his day and acted like everything was normal. And in a way, it was normal. This was my life, this was who I was, the woman who ate delivery with her boyfriend and watched TV and went to bed at a reasonable hour.

But there was another woman now. A woman who climbed stairs to the third floor and lay in rumpled sheets and let rough hands trace patterns all over her skin.

I didn't know which one was real anymore.

Chapter 7

The next time I went up, I put on a dress.

It wasn't the sundress from before, it was a different one, dark blue, fitted, the kind of thing I never wore. I'd bought it months ago for a work event and then chickened out and worn pants instead. It had been hanging in the back of my closet with the tags still on.

I cut off the tags that morning while Callum was in the shower. I put on the dress and looked at myself in the mirror. It hugged my waist and fell just above my knees and showed more of my legs than I was used to showing. I looked like someone else. Someone who went places and did things and didn't apologize all the time.

I put on mascara and lipstick, a muted rose color I'd forgotten I owned and I looked at myself again.

Then I took off the dress and put on jeans and a sweater and looked at myself again. I looked like me again, quiet, invisible, and safe.

I took off the jeans and put the dress back on.

Callum came out of the bathroom with a towel around his waist.

"Wow," he said. "You look nice. What's the occasion?"

"I'm meeting Sarah for lunch. She wanted to try a new place downtown."

"Well have fun." He kissed my cheek, careful not to smudge my lipstick. "You should dress up more often. You look great."

"Thanks."

I waited until he left for work. I stood in the apartment alone and looked at the door. I could take off the dress and put on my regular clothes and buy groceries and come home and make stuff. I could do all the things I was supposed to do.

Instead I climbed the stairs to the third floor.

I stood outside his door for a long time, debating. My hand was raised to knock but I couldn't make myself do it. I thought about turning around. I thought about going back downstairs and pretending none of this had ever happened. I thought about the way Callum had kissed my cheek that morning, careful and sweet.

But I knocked.

Deke opened the door and stopped. His eyes moved down my body and back up, slow and appreciative.

"Well, well," he said.

"I shouldn't even be here."

"And yet."

"I'm serious. This is a total mistake."

He leaned against the doorframe and crossed his arms. He didn't invite me in, he just looked at me with that easy smile, waiting.

"So go," he said.

I didn't move.

"The stairs are right there," he said. "Go back to your apartment. Make some tea. Read a book. Forget you ever knocked on my door."

I still didn't move.

"Or," he said, "you can come inside."

"I can't."

"You can. You just don't want to admit you want to."

I looked at him. He was infuriating just standing there, giving me the choice, making me own whatever I decided.

"You know I want to," I said. The words came out quiet, almost a whisper.

"Then get inside."

I stepped past him into his apartment. My heart was pounding so hard I could feel it in my throat.

He closed the door behind me.

"Sit down," he said. "I'll get us something to drink."

I sat on the couch and crossed my legs. The dress rode up a little. I pulled it down, then stopped. I let it go.

He came back with two glasses of whiskey. He handed me one and sat down next to me, close, his knee pressing against mine.

"You're shaking," he said.

"I know I am."

"Why you shaking?"

"Because I shouldn't be here. Because this is wrong. Because I have a . . ."
"I stopped myself. I didn't say it. The word felt too heavy to speak.

"Drink," he said. "It'll help calm you."

I took a sip. It burned going down and I coughed, and he laughed.

"Easy," he said. "That's the good stuff. You're supposed to savor it."

I took another sip, smaller this time. The burn was still there, but underneath it was something warm and smooth. I felt it spread through my chest and settle in my stomach.

"Better?" he asked.

"A little."

He set his glass on the coffee table and turned to face me. His hand came up and touched my hair, tucking a strand behind my ear.

"I like the lipstick," he said.

"I shouldn't be here."

"You just got here."

"I know. But I shouldn't."

He touched his thumb to my lower lip, tracing the color. I stopped talking. I stopped breathing.

"You're so scared," he said. "What are you scared of?"

"Everything."

"That's hardly an answer."

"I'm scared of wanting this." The words came out before I could stop them. "I'm scared of how much I want this."

He smiled. "That's the one thing you shouldn't be scared of."

He leaned in and kissed me, soft at first, probing. I didn't pull away. I should have. Instead, I leaned into him, and the kiss deepened and my hand came up and grabbed the front of his shirt.

He pulled back. His lips were stained pink from my lipstick.

"That color looks good on you," I said.

He laughed with that deep surprised laugh I was starting to crave. "You're funny, quiet girl.. I didn't know you were so funny."

"There's a lot you don't know about me."

"I'm starting to figure that out."

He kissed me again, and this time his hands found my waist. I felt myself melting into him despite everything. Despite knowing it was wrong, despite knowing I should stop. But my body didn't care about should anymore. It only knew that his hands felt good and his mouth felt better and I wanted more.

His fingers traced patterns on my hip through the thin fabric of my dress.

"You know what I think?" he said against my mouth.

"What?"

"I think you've been hiding, playing it safe, being the good quiet girl."

"Maybe I really am a good quiet girl."

"No." His hand moved lower to the hem of my dress, to the bare skin of my thigh. "A good girl wouldn't be here. A good girl wouldn't have worn this dress up here. A good girl wouldn't be looking at me the way you're looking at me right now."

I pulled back. "I should go."

"You keep saying that."

"I mean it this time."

"Okay then." He removed his hand from my thigh and leaned back against the couch relaxed as anything. "Go."

I sat there didn't move.

"Tiff."

I looked at him.

"We can just sit here. Talk. Drink whiskey. I'm not going to push you."

"That's the problem," I said.

"What is?"

"That you're not pushing. If you pushed, I could say no. I could blame you. But you're not pushing. You're just waiting so that whatever happens is my fault."

"There's no fault." He reached out and took my hand. His fingers were warm and dry. "It's about what you want. What do you want?"

I looked at our hands together. His was so much bigger than mine. I could feel his pulse in his fingertips.

"I don't even know," I said.

"Yes, you do."

"I want..." I stopped. I couldn't say it.

"Say it."

"I want you to kiss me again."

He smiled. He brought my hand to his lips and kissed my knuckles, one by one. Then he leaned in and kissed me, slow and deep on the mouth.

This time, I didn't fight it. I let myself fall into the kiss, let myself feel it, let my body take over. His hands came back to my waist and pulled me closer, and I went willingly. I shifted on the couch until I was pressed against his side, and then somehow I was in his lap all over, straddling him, my dress hiked up around my thighs.

I pulled back, breathing hard.

"I should. . . "

"Stop saying that."

"But I . . . "

He put his finger to my lips. "Every time you say should, you're thinking about someone else. What someone else wants. What someone else expects. What about what you want?"

I looked at him. My heart was pounding. My whole body was trembling.

"I want this," I said.

"Then take it."

I kissed him hard and desperate. I grabbed his face in both hands and kissed him like I was drowning and he was air. His hands ran up my bare thighs and settled on my hips under my dress and I rolled against him and felt him groan into my mouth.

Then I stopped. I pulled back, panting.

"I just can't," I said. "I can't do this."

"Okay."

"I'm serious. This is too much. This is too fast."

"Okay." He loosened his grip on my hips. "We can stop."

I was still sitting in his lap. I could feel him beneath me, hard through his jeans. I could feel the heat of him, the want. But he wasn't moving, he was just waiting, letting me decide everything.

I climbed off his lap and sat on the couch next to him and I pulled my dress down. My hands were shaking.

"I'm sorry," I said.

"Don't be sorry."

"I just need, I need to think. I need to . . . "

"You don't have to explain." He reached out and took my hand again. "We just sit here."

So we sat there. The apartment was quiet except for the sound of traffic outside and the hum of his refrigerator and his music on soft.

After a while, I felt my breathing slow. I felt my heart stop racing. I felt the panic recede, leaving something else behind. Something that felt like clarity.

"Deke."

"Yeah."

"I want to kiss you again."

"Okay."

I turned and kissed him, softer this time, and slower. I let myself feel it without the panic, without the guilt, just the sensation of his lips against mine and his hand in my hair.

He kissed me back, matching my pace, all warmth and want and the slow build of something inevitable.

His hands found the hem of my dress again. He paused, waiting.

"Yes," I said against his mouth.

His fingers traced up my thigh, slow and light. Goosebumps rose in their wake. He reached the edge of my underwear and stopped, his thumb tracing along the elastic.

I tensed and he felt it.

"We can stop," he said.

"I don't want to stop."

"You sure?"

I wasn't sure. I wasn't sure of anything except that his hand on my thigh felt like fire and I didn't want the fire to go out.

"I'm sure," I said.

His fingers slipped under the elastic and touched me closer. I gasped, and my hand flew up and grabbed his wrist.

"Sorry," I said. "Sorry, I just . . ."

"It's okay." He stopped his hand but didn't remove it. "We go slow."

"I don't know what I'm doing."

"You don't have to know. You just feel."

I loosened my grip on his wrist. He started moving again, slow and gentle, exploring. I closed my eyes and tried to let go, tried to stop thinking, tried to just be in my body.

Chapter 8

It felt good, terrifyingly good. His fingers moved in slow circles and I could feel the pressure building, feel it coiling tight in my lower belly. My thighs were trembling. My breathing was ragged.

"That's it," he said. "Just let yourself feel it."

I was making sounds I didn't recognize, small, light, desperate sounds. My hips were moving against his hand.

"Deke," I said. "I don't, I can't . . . "

"You can. Just let go."

But I couldn't because letting go meant admitting that I wanted this, that I was here by choice, that I was doing this thing that I shouldn't be doing. The pleasure and the guilt tangled up together until I couldn't tell them apart.

I grabbed his wrist again and pulled his hand away.

"I can't," I said. "I'm sorry, I can't."

He withdrew his hand. He didn't look frustrated or annoyed. He just looked at me with that same patient, calm, expression.

"Okay," he said.

"I'm sorry."

"Stop apologizing."

My whole body was shaking. I felt like I was going to cry or scream or both.

"Hey." He reached out and cupped my face. "Look at me."

I looked at him.

"There's no rush," he said. "We have all the time in the world."

"I'm going to go."

"Yeah."

I stood up. My legs were unsteady. I smoothed down my dress and looked around for my shoes, which I'd kicked off at some point.

"Tiff."

I looked back at him and waved a tiny finger wave. I went down back to our apartment. I locked the door behind me and went straight to the bathroom and looked at myself in the mirror. My lipstick was smeared. My hair was messed. My eyes were bright and my cheeks were flushed.

I looked like someone who had done something she shouldn't have done.

I washed my face, fixed my hair. I changed into my regular clothes and sat on the couch and stared at the wall and tried to figure out what I was going to do.

When Callum came home, I was making dinner like nothing happened.

"Hey," he said. "How was lunch with Sarah?"

"Great. The restaurant was nice. We talked for a long time."

"That's great. You've been seeming a little down lately. It's good you got out."

"Yeah." I stirred the sauce on the stove. "It was really good."

He came up behind me and wrapped his arms around my waist and rested his chin on my shoulder.

I told myself I was done. I threw myself into my regular life with a kind of desperate energy. I cleaned the apartment until it sparkled. I reorganized the bookshelf by genre instead of alphabetically. I cooked elaborate dinners that took hours to prepare. I went to bed early and woke up early and filled every minute with activity just so I wouldn't have time to think.

Callum noticed.

"You're like a tornado lately," he said on Saturday morning, watching me scrub the grout between the bathroom tiles with a toothbrush.

"Spring cleaning."

"It's October."

"Fall cleaning, then."

He laughed and shook his head and went back to his games. He was good at everything. He was dependable and kind and he loved me.

I scrubbed the grout harder.

On Sunday, I went to the grocery store and took the long way home, walking through the park, sat on a bench, watched the leaves fall. An old man fed pigeons nearby. A woman jogged past with a golden retriever. The world went on, ordinary and uncomplicated, and I tried to feel like I was part of it.

On Monday, I went to work and shelved books and helped a little girl find a picture book about elephants. She had pigtails and a gap-toothed smile and she hugged the book to her chest like it was treasure. I watched her run back to her mother and I thought about innocence and then guilt.

On Tuesday, I was putting away laundry when I found the blue dress crumpled at the back of my closet. I'd shoved it there after that day, not wanting to look at it. I pulled it out and held it up and looked at it.

I put it back, took it out again, put it on.

I stood in front of the mirror and looked at myself. The woman who looked back at me was not the woman who scrubbed grout and shelved books and cooked elaborate dinners. She was someone else with flushed cheeks and bright eyes and a mouth that remembered being kissed.

I took off the dress and put on jeans and a sweater. I went to the kitchen and made tea. I sat on the couch and read my book.

The same page seven times.

On Wednesday, Callum had to work late. "Don't wait up," he said that morning. "Big thing going on, lots of overtime though. I might be there until midnight."

"Okay. Good luck."

"Thanks." He kissed my forehead. "There's leftover pasta in the fridge if you want."

I watched him leave. I listened to his footsteps on the stairs. I heard the front door of the building open and close. It was the worst sound possible.

I sat on the couch for an hour and tried to read. I tried to watch TV. I tried to convince myself that I was a person who stayed home and ate leftover pasta and went to bed at a reasonable hour.

At seven o'clock, I put on the blue dress. I didn't let myself think about it, I just did it. I put on the heels and the lipstick, too. I looked at myself in the mirror and I didn't recognize myself and I liked it.

I climbed the stairs to the third floor. The door opened before I could knock.

"I was wondering when you'd come back," he said.

"How did you know I was here?"

"I heard the heels on the stairs." He smiled that slow warm smile. "You don't usually wear heels."

"I don't usually do a lot of things."

He stepped back and I walked inside. The apartment was dim, lit only by lamps on the coffee table and the kitchen counter. Music was playing, something low and sultry that I didn't recognize.

"You were expecting me," I said.

"I was hoping."

He closed the door behind me. I stood in the middle of his living room, my heart pounding, my palms sweating.

"I tried to stay away," I said.

"I know."

"I can't stop thinking about you."

"I know that too."

He walked toward me, slow, giving me time to run. But I didn't run. I stood there and watched him approach me like prey watching a predator, knowing what was coming, unable to move.

He stopped in front of me. He reached out and touched my face, his thumb tracing along my cheekbone.

"You look beautiful," he said.

"I feel crazy."

"Crazy's not always that bad, believe me."

He kissed me soft at first, then deeper. I grabbed the front of his shirt and pulled him closer, and he made a sound low in his throat that sent heat flooding through me.

"I want . . . " I started.

"What do you want?"

I looked at him. I thought about all the things I'd been taught to want. Safety. Stability. A good man who loved me. A quiet life.

"I want to feel alive."

"We can do alive," he smirked.

He kissed me again, and his hands found the zipper at the back of my dress. He pulled it down slow, one tooth at a time, and the fabric loosened around me. He pushed the straps off my shoulders and the dress fell to the floor, pooling at my feet.

I was wearing the black bra and underwear again. I'd worn them on purpose and this time I didn't pretend it was an accident.

He stepped back and looked at me. His eyes moved over my body, taking in every curve, every line. I felt exposed. I felt powerful. I felt like a different person.

"Come here," he said.

I stepped out of my dress and walked toward him. He took my hand and led me to the couch. He sat down and pulled me onto his lap, facing him, my knees on either side of his hips, me in bra, panties, and heels. I felt dangerous, I felt sexy.

"Tell me what you want," he said.

"I don't know how."

"Yeah, you do. You just need practice."

He put his hands on my thighs, resting them there, not moving. Waiting for me.

I took a breath. "I want you to touch me."

"Where?"

My face burned. "Everywhere."

He smiled. "That's a good start."

His hands moved up my thighs, slow and careful. They traced over my hips, my waist, my ribs. He unhooked my bra with practiced fingers and slid it off my shoulders, and then his hands were on my bare breasts, cupping them, his thumbs brushing across my nipples.

I arched into his touch. My hands found his shoulders, gripping hard.

"More," I whispered.

"More what?"

"More everything."

He leaned forward and took my nipple in his mouth. I gasped, my head falling back, my fingers digging into his shoulders. He sucked and licked and bit gently, and every sensation shot straight down between my legs. I was grinding against him without meaning to, seeking friction, seeking relief.

"You're very responsive," he said against my skin. "Like you've been waiting your whole life for someone to touch you like this."

"I have."

He switched to my other breast, giving it the same attention. I was making sounds now, sounds I couldn't control, sounds that would have embarrassed me a week ago. Now I didn't care. I just wanted more.

"Stand up," he said.

I climbed off his lap on shaky legs. He stood up too and took my hand and led me to his bedroom. The bed was unmade, the sheets rumpled. He laid me down in the middle of it and stood there looking at me.

"I want to look all of you," he said.

I hooked my thumbs in the waistband of my underwear but hesitated. This was further than I'd ever gone. This was the point of no return.

I pushed them down.

He inhaled sharp. His eyes moved over me, hungry and appreciative. I lay there, completely bare, completely exposed, and I waited for the shame to hit. But it didn't. Instead, I felt something else. Pride? Power? His gaze made me writhe under him.

"You're incredible," he said.

"Show me."

He pulled his shirt over his head and climbed onto the bed. He settled between my legs, his body warm and solid above me. He kissed my mouth, my jaw, my neck. He kissed his way down my body, taking his time, tasting every inch of skin. My whole body contorted madly.

When he reached my hips, he paused.

"Tell me what you want," he said.

"I want your mouth on me."

The words came out stronger than I expected. He smiled against my hip.

"That's a good girl," he said.

He lowered his head and I felt his breath against me, warm and soft. Then his tongue, tracing slow circles, exploring. I grabbed the sheets with both hands, twisted them up, and held on.

Chapter 9

He took his time. He learned my body, figured out what made me gasp and what made me moan and what made my hips jerk up off the bed. He brought me to the edge and backed off, brought me to the edge again and backed off, until I was begging him, saying please over and over, saying his name like a prayer.

"Not yet," he said against me. "I want to hear you beg for it."

"Please," I said. "Please, I am begging!"

"For what?"

"I need to, I need . . . " I couldn't say the words. They stuck in my throat.

"Say it, Tiff."

"I need to come. Please, Deke, I need to come."

His tongue moved faster, his fingers slipped inside me, curling, hitting a spot that made stars explode behind my eyes. The pressure built and then it broke, and I was crying out, my body arching high off the bed, waves of pleasure crashing through me so intense I thought I would shatter.

I lay there panting, trembling, tears leaking from the corners of my eyes. He climbed up my body and kissed me, and I could taste myself on his lips.

"How was that?" he asked.

I laughed, a little hysterically. "I think you know." I playfully slapped his face and rolled my eyes.

He smiled and brushed the hair back from my face.

I looked down between us. He was still hard, straining against his jeans. I reached down and touched him through the denim, and he sucked in a breath.

"You don't have to."

"I want to."

I pushed him onto his back and straddled him. I unbuckled his belt with steady hands, unzipped his jeans, pulled them down along with his boxers. He was beautiful, all of him, and I took a moment just to look.

Then I wrapped my hand around him and watched his face change.

"Tiff," he said.

"Just feel it, you said," and I smiled and shook my head at him.

I stroked him slow, learning him the way he'd learned me. I watched his jaw tighten and his eyes go dark. I watched his hands curl up in the sheets. I liked having this power, liked knowing I could make him lose control.

I bent down and kissed the tip of him. He groaned like he was dying. I pushed my lips harder against him, like I was refusing him. He breathed harder. I licked from the base to the head and he arched in his back like he made me arch earlier.

When he seized my head in his hands and made clear he wanted no more games, I took him in my mouth, slow smooth and all the way I could in one long motion.

He made a sound like I'd punched him, and his hands tangled in my hair.

"Jesus," he said. "Where did you, how do you . . . "

I didn't answer. I just kept going, taking him deeper, using my hand and my mouth together. I was improvising, following instinct, paying attention to what made him groan and what made him gasp. His hips started moving, making little thrusts he couldn't seem to control, and I let him, let him take what he needed.

"Tiff," he said. "I'm going to, if you don't stop . . . "

But I didn't stop. I plunged fully and completely up and down his entire length. I wanted to feel it in him, I wanted to know I could do this to him. I didn't want him to know I'd been practicing with zucchini's like a web site said to.

His whole body went taut. His hand tightened in my hair and he made a sound that was almost a shout. I pumped hand and mouth up and down on him faster, lighter. I groaned on him to vibrate him. I slithered my tongue around him inside. I swear to god, him rising up off the bed and into my mouth was making me nearly come again.

He stopped moving and stopped breathing but I didn't stop at all. Still, it was unexpected. Suddenly he was spilling into my mouth, hot, full, and salty, and I swallowed all of him without thinking about it, or at least as much as I could.

He pulled me up and kissed me, deep and long. "Holy shit," he said.

I smiled against his mouth. "Was that good?"

"Good?" He laughed. "That was fucking incredible."

I crawled up beside him full of pride and wonder and we lay there for a long time, tangled together in his rumpled sheets. He traced patterns on my back and I listened to his heartbeat slow. The candle in the other room had

burned low, and the music had quieted, and the apartment was still except for our breathing.

"Now I really should go," I said eventually.

"I know."

But still I didn't move and neither did he.

"Tiff."

"Yeah?"

"You're different now. You know that, right? Different than when you first knocked on my door."

"I know that."

"Is that a good thing?"

I thought about it. I thought about the woman I'd been a month ago, the woman who faded into the background and preferred books to parties and never wore blue dresses or heels. And then I thought about the woman I was now, lying naked in a man's bed, tasting him on my lips.

"I don't know," I said. "Maybe ask me later when I haven't just come with a man like you."

He smiled and kissed my forehead. "Fair enough."

I got dressed in the dim light of his bedroom letting him watch me. I found my underwear on the floor and my bra tangled in the sheets. I put on my dress and zipped it up and checked my reflection in his mirror. My hair was a mess. My lipstick was long gone. My eyes were bright and a little wild.

"Friday?" he asked.

"I have to work Friday."

"Saturday, then."

"Callum will be home Saturday."

"Sunday."

I turned and looked at him. He was still lying in bed, the sheet pulled up to his knees, watching me with that easy smile.

I gazed at his form, all of him. "Sunday," I said. "But I can only come for a little while."

"A little while is all we need."

I went down the stairs on unsteady legs. I let myself into the apartment and went straight to the shower. I washed his scent off my skin and watched the water swirl down the drain. I dried off and put on my softest pajamas and climbed into bed.

When Callum came home at midnight, I pretended to be asleep.

He climbed into bed beside me and put his arm around my waist. He smelled like coffee and work, familiar and safe.

"Love you," he murmured against my hair, already half asleep.

"You too," I whispered.

I stared at the ceiling and fell happily asleep.

Sunday arrived fast. Callum went to hockey and breakfast with some friends and I told him I was going to stay home and read.

"You sure you don't want to come?" he asked. "Everyone would love to see you."

"I think I'll just have a quiet morning. You know me."

"Okay." He kissed my forehead. "I'll bring you back a pastry."

I waited until I heard him leave the building. Then I threw myself out of bed, put on a short skirt this time with a fitted top that showed off my collarbone. I'd bought new underwear, red lace. I'd never owned red lace before, never felt like it was me.

I dashed up the stairs to the third floor.

He opened the door before I knocked, like he'd been waiting for me.

"Do come in," he said.

The apartment smelled like fresh coffee and something sweet, like he'd been baking. There was music playing, something with a slow beat that I could feel in my chest.

"You made breakfast," I said, looking at the kitchen counter where a plate of eggs sat next to a bowl of fruit.

"I figured you might be hungry."

"I'm not hungry for food."

He raised an eyebrow. "Look who's getting so bold."

I walked up to him and grabbed the front of his shirt and pulled him down and kissed him. He made a surprised sound against my mouth, then smiled and kissed me back.

"Someone woke up on the right side of bed," he said.

"I didn't even sleep."

"No?"

"I kept thinking about today."

"What about today?"

I looked at him with narrow eyes. He was playing stupid. I thought about all the things I wanted to say, all the things I wanted to do. I thought about

the woman I'd been before I started climbing these stairs, and the woman I was becoming, and how far apart they were already.

"I want to try something," I said.

"What kind of something?"

I pushed him toward the couch. He went willingly, letting me guide him, watching me with curious eyes. I pushed him down and he sat, and I stood in front of him.

"Just watch," I said.

I reached down and pulled my top over my head. His eyes went dark. I reached behind me and unhooked my bra, let it fall. I unzipped my skirt and let it drop to the floor. I stood there in nothing but the red lace underwear, and I watched his face as he looked at me.

"Jesus Christ," he said.

"You like?"

"Come here."

"Not yet." I hooked my thumbs in the waistband of the underwear. "I want you to watch."

I pulled them down, slow, stepping out of them one foot at a time. I stood there completely bare, completely exposed, and I didn't feel ashamed. I felt powerful. I felt free.

"Tiff," he said, and his voice was rough.

"Touch yourself."

His eyes widened. "What?"

"I want to watch you. The way you're watching me."

He held my gaze for a long moment. Then he reached down and unbuckled his belt, unzipped his jeans, pulled himself out. He was already hard, already wanting, and he wrapped his hand around himself and started stroking, slow and deliberate.

I watched his hand move, watched his face change, watched his breathing go ragged. It was the most erotic thing I'd ever seen. All the while, I worked a finger inside myself, delicately drew it over my clit, sucked on it to make it more wet.

"Come here," he said again. "Please."

I walked slow toward him and straddled his lap. He let go of himself and his hands came to my hips, pulling me against him. I could feel him hot and hard between my legs, pressed against my center, and I ground down against him.

We both groaned.

"I want . . . " I started.

"What do you want?"

"I want to feel you. Not inside, not yet, but just against me. I want to feel you against me down there." I sank my tongue violently into his mouth because I could barely believe what I was saying.

He shifted his hips and pressed himself against me, and we moved together, grinding, rocking, finding a rhythm. The friction was incredible, his hardness sliding against my wetness, and every stroke sent sparks shooting through me.

"You feel so good," he said. "So wet, so hot."

"Don't stop" I cried in a whisper.

"I'm not stopping."

We moved together like that, faster now, more urgent. His hands gripped my hips, guiding my movements, and I braced my hands on his shoulders and rode him, feeling the sensation, the wave of pleasure building inside me.

"I'm close," I said. "I'm so close."

"Look at me."

I opened my eyes. He was looking at me with such intensity, such focus, like I was the only thing in the world that mattered.

"Let go," he said.

The wave immediately crested and broke. I cried out, my body convulsing, my nails digging into his shoulders. He held me through it, kept moving, prolonging the pleasure until I was shaking and gasping and couldn't take any more.

I climbed off his lap and knelt on the floor between his legs. I took him in my hand, then in my mouth. I was better at this now, more confident. I knew what he liked, what made him groan, what made his hips jerk up at my face.

"Tiff," he said. "Tiff, I'm going to . . . "

I took him deeper, relaxed my throat, let him thrust into my mouth. He made a strangled sound and his whole body went rigid, and I felt him pulse against my tongue, tasted the salt of him as he spilled.

I climbed back onto the couch and curled up against him. He put his arm around me and pulled me close. I pulled the blanket up over us.

"Where did you come from?" he asked.

"2B."

He laughed. "Smart ass."

"You love it."

"I like everything about you."

We lay there for a while, catching our breath. The eggs on the counter were getting cold, and the coffee was probably lukewarm, and I didn't care about any of it.

"I gotta go," I said eventually. "He'll be home soon."

I got dressed slowly this time, taking my time, letting him watch. I liked the way he looked at me, like I was something precious, something worth looking at.

"He has a work dinner on Thursday. He won't be home until late."

"Thursday it is then."

I went down the stairs and back to our apartment. I showered and changed and was sitting on the couch with a book when Callum came home.

"Hey," he said. "I brought you a croissant."

"Great!"

He sat down next to me and kissed my cheek. "Good morning?"

"Yeah. Quiet. I just read down here and relaxed." I bit my lip. Down here?

"You look different," he said, studying my face. "Refreshed or something."

"I took a long shower. Must be the steam."

He smiled and turned on the TV, and we watched a show together. I ate the croissant he'd brought me, and I thought about Thursday.

Callum left for workout at six, kissing me on the forehead as he headed out the door.

"Have fun."

"Fun is not the word I'd use." He rolled his eyes. "Save me some of whatever you're making for dinner."

"I was just going to make soup."

"Save me soup, then."

The door closed behind him. I listened to his footsteps on the stairs, listened to the front door of the building open and close. I counted to one hundred. And I went to the bedroom and opened my closet.

Chapter 10

I'd bought something new for Deke. A dress, if you could call it that. It was barely more than a slip, black silk that skimmed my body and ended high on my thighs. I'd hidden it in the back of my closet, still in the shopping bag, tags still on. I'd told myself I wasn't going to wear it. I'd told myself I'd bought it by accident, a moment of weakness, something I'd return.

I put it on and looked at myself in the mirror. The silk moved against my skin like water, clinging to every curve. I wasn't wearing anything underneath. I'd decided that in the store, standing in the dressing room with my heart pounding, imagining the look on his face when he saw me.

I put on heels. I put on lipstick, darker this time, almost red. I put on mascara and eyeliner and did something with my hair that made it fall in waves around my shoulders.

I looked like a woman I didn't recognize. I looked like a woman who did what she wanted.

I climbed the stairs to the third floor. He was wearing jeans and nothing else, his chest bare, his feet too. He looked at me and his jaw actually dropped.

"Holy shit," he said.

"May I please come in?"

"You better get in here before I lose my mind."

I walked past him into the apartment. I could feel his eyes on me, feel the heat of his gaze tracing up and down my body. I walked to the middle of the living room and turned around slowly, letting him look.

"You like?" I asked.

"Like?" He closed the door and walked toward me. "I'm going to remember this moment for the rest of my life."

"That's the idea."

He reached out and touched the strap of the dress, running his finger along the silk where it crossed my shoulder.

"What's underneath?" he asked.

"Nothing."

His eyes went dark. His hand tightened on the strap.

"Say that again."

"Nothing." I stepped closer to him, close enough that my breasts brushed against his chest through the thin silk. "I'm not wearing anything underneath." I kissed him and moaned. "In case it gets in our way," I murmured.

He made a sound low in his throat, something between a groan and a growl. His hands came to my hips and he pulled me against him, and I could feel how hard he was already, pressing against my stomach through his jeans.

"You're trying to kill me," he said.

"Maybe I am."

"It's working."

He kissed me, hard and desperate, and his hands roamed over my body, feeling the silk, feeling the shape of me beneath it. I kissed him back just as hard, my hands on his chest, his shoulders, his back. I raked my nails down his skin and felt him shudder.

"Bedroom?" I said against his mouth.

"Bossy."

"You love it."

"I do love it."

He picked me up and I wrapped my legs around his waist. He carried me to the bedroom and dropped me on the bed. I bounced on the mattress and laughed, and he stood there looking down at me with hunger in his eyes.

"Take it off," he said.

"Make me."

His eyebrows shot up. "Oh, it's like that now?"

"It's like that," I said and I laughed hysterically.

He climbed onto the bed and I scrambled backward, laughing. He grabbed my ankle and pulled me back toward him across the sheet. I squealed and kicked at him playfully, and he caught my other ankle and pinned both my legs down.

"You think you can get away from me?" he said.

"I think I can try."

He crawled up my body and I squirmed beneath him, twisting, trying to escape even though I didn't want to. He grabbed my wrists and pinned them above my head, and I arched up against him, breathing hard, grinning.

"Caught you," he said.

"Now what are you going to do with me?"

He kissed me instead of answering. His mouth was hot and demanding, and I kissed him back, straining against his grip on my wrists. He held me down and kissed my jaw, my neck, the spot behind my ear that made me gasp.

"Still wearing the dress," he murmured against my skin.

"Still haven't made me take it off."

He let go of my wrists and sat back on his heels. I propped myself up on my elbows and looked at him, and he looked at me, and something passed between us. Something playful. Something new.

"Take it off," he said again. "Pretty please."

"Since you asked so nicely."

I sat up and reached for the hem of the dress. I pulled it up slowly, inch by inch, watching his face as I revealed more skin. His eyes followed the fabric, hungry and intent. I pulled it up over my hips, my stomach, my breasts. I pulled it up over my head and tossed it aside.

He inhaled sharp. I was completely bare now, and I lay back on the bed and stretched out, letting him look his fill.

"Your turn," I said.

He stood up and unbuckled his belt. He unzipped his jeans and pushed them down, and then he was naked too, and I let my eyes roam over him. He was beautiful. All of him. Hard and ready and wanting.

He climbed back onto the bed and settled between my legs. I could feel him against my thigh, hot and heavy, and I shifted my hips so that he slid higher, closer to where I wanted him.

"Tiff," he said.

"Mmm?"

"I want . . ."

"I know what you want."

I reached down between us and wrapped my fingers around him. He groaned and his hips jerked forward. I stroked him slowly, watching his face, watching him lose control.

"I've been thinking about this all week," I said.

"Me too."

"I've been thinking about what it would feel like." I shifted my hips again, and this time when he slid forward, I angled myself so the tip of him brushed against my entrance just barely. Just a whisper of contact.

He froze. His whole body went taut.

"Tiff," he said, and his voice was strained.

"Yes?"

"Are you, do you want?"

"I don't know yet." I smiled up at him. "I'm still deciding, aren't I." I laughed again.

I shifted my hips again, letting him press against me just a little more. I could feel the heat of him, the pressure, the promise of what could happen if I just let him push forward. My body wanted it. My body was aching for it. But there was something delicious about this, about holding him right there on the edge, about having all the power.

"You're teasing me," he said.

"Am I? Poor baby."

I rolled my hips in a slow circle, letting him slide against my wetness, letting him feel how ready I was. He groaned and his arms trembled where they held him above me.

"That's definitely teasing."

"Maybe I like teasing."

I pushed against his chest and he let me, rolling onto his back. I climbed on top of him and straddled his hips, and now I was the one looking down, I was the one in control. I reached between us and positioned him at my entrance, and I sank down just enough to take the very tip of him inside me.

We both gasped.

"Tiff," he said.

I rose back up, letting him slip out. He made a sound of frustration and his hands gripped my hips.

"Don't," he said. "Don't stop."

"Don't stop what, baby?" I asked as innocently as I could pretend.

I sank down again so that just the tip, just that first incredible inch, slipped between my folds, and then rose back up. His hands tightened on my hips, trying to pull me down, but I resisted him.

"You're killing me," he said.

"I know."

I did it again. And again. Each time I took just a little more of him, just a little deeper, before pulling back. His face was contorted with pleasure and frustration, his chest heaving, his hands gripping my hips hard enough to leave bruises.

"Please," he said.

"Please what?"

"Please, Tiff. I need, need you to . . . "

"Need me to what?" I sank down a little deeper this time, maybe a half inch, and his eyes rolled back. "This?"

"Yes. More. Please."

I rose back up, all the way, until he slipped out completely. He made a sound that was almost a sob.

"You're evil," he said.

"You love it."

I bent down and kissed him, slow and deep, while my hips hovered just above his. I could feel him straining up toward me, trying to find his way back inside, but I kept myself just out of his reach.

"Tell me how much you want me," I said against his mouth.

"More than anything."

"Tell me what you want to do to me."

"I want to fuck you." His voice was ragged, desperate. "I want to feel you around me. I want to make you scream my name."

"Mmm." I reached between us and guided him back to my entrance. I let him press against me, let him feel the heat and the wetness, but I still didn't let him in. "Like this?"

"Tiff. Please." His voice shook.

"I like hearing you beg."

I sank down just a fraction, just enough to take the head of him inside me again. I held myself there, feeling the stretch, feeling him pulse against my inner walls. His hands were shaking on my hips.

"More," he said.

"Not yet."

I rose back up and he slipped out, and I rolled off of him and lay on my back next to him, stretching out like a cat in the sun. He turned onto his side and looked at me with wild eyes.

"What are you doing?" he asked.

"Taking a break."

"A break? You can't take a break. Not now."

"Can't I?"

I stretched my arms above my head and arched my back, knowing exactly what I looked like, knowing exactly what I was doing to him. He

reached out and touched my breast, his thumb circling my nipple, and I sighed with pleasure.

"You're the most infuriating woman I've ever met," he said.

"Thank you."

"That wasn't a compliment."

"Yes it was."

He rolled on top of me and pinned me down, and this time when he positioned himself at my entrance, I didn't stop him. He pressed forward, just the tip, and then he stopped.

"How does that feel?" he asked.

"Pretty good."

"Just pretty good?"

"Really good?"

He pushed a little deeper, maybe an inch, and then stopped again. My breath caught.

"Still good?" he asked.

"Yes."

"You want more?"

"Please.," I had to whisper.

But he didn't give me more. He pulled back, almost all the way out, and then pushed forward again, just that first inch. He was doing to me what I'd done to him. Teasing. Torturing. Driving me insane.

"Deke," I said.

"Yes?"

"Don't be cruel."

"I'm not cruel." He pulled back and pushed forward again, just that shallow thrust, over and over. "I'm thorough."

I grabbed his ass and tried to pull him deeper, but he resisted, laughing against my neck.

"Patience," he said.

"I don't have patience."

"You had plenty of patience when you were teasing me."

"That was different."

"How was it different?"

"I was in control."

He looked at me, and something shifted in his expression. Something soft, something tender.

"You're always in control," he said. "Even now."

I looked at him hovering above me, his body trembling with restraint, his eyes warm despite his desperation. He meant it. He would stop right now if I asked. He would give me more if I asked. It was always my choice.

"More," I said. "But slow." I sank my tongue into his mouth.

He pushed deeper, one inch at a time, letting me feel every fraction of progress. I felt myself stretching, opening, making room for him. It was overwhelming. It was too much. It was perfect.

"More?"

"Yes."

He kept going, slow and steady, until he was all the way inside and we were pressed together from hip to chest. We both held still, breathing hard, adjusting.

"God," he said. "You feel incredible."

"So do you."

He started to move. Slow at first, pulling out and pushing back in with long, deliberate strokes. I wrapped my legs around his waist and moved with him, meeting his thrusts, finding our rhythm.

"Is this what you were thinking about all week?" he asked.

"Exactly this," I groaned.

"Is it what you imagined?"

"Better."

He smiled and kissed me, and then he started moving faster. The bed creaked beneath us. I could hear the sound of our bodies coming together, could hear my own voice making sounds I didn't recognize. I was loud, louder than I'd ever been. I didn't care.

"Yes," I said. "Yes, like that, don't stop . . . "

Chapter 11

He shifted the angle and hit a spot inside me that made me cry out loud. He did it again, and again, and I was clawing at his back, digging my nails into his skin, making sounds that echoed off the walls.

"You're so loud," he said against my neck. "I love it. Let the whole building hear you."

"Don't stop," I gasped. "Please don't stop," I panted.

He didn't stop. He drove into me harder, faster, and I was lost, I was drowning, I was nothing but sensation. The pressure built until I couldn't take it anymore, until I was right on the edge. The bed banged the wall.

"Let go," he said.

I shattered. The climax tore through me and I screamed his name mixed with words I didn't know I knew. My body clenched around him and I felt him groan against my neck, felt his rhythm stutter.

His breathing stopped.

"Yes. Do it, inside me," I groaned.

He thrust once more, twice, and then he was coming too, his whole body shaking, his face buried in my neck, making sounds that sent another wave of pleasure rolling through me.

We collapsed together, panting, sweating, tangled up in each other. He was still inside me and I didn't want him to move. I didn't want the moment to end.

"Holy shit," he said eventually.

I laughed. It came out breathless and a little hysterical. "Yeah."

"That teasing thing you did. At the beginning."

"What about it?"

"That was the hottest thing anyone has ever done to me."

I smiled against his shoulder. "Yeah?"

"I almost died. Literally. My heart almost stopped."

"I liked it. Having that power over you."

"You always have power over me." He lifted his head and looked at me.

We lay there for a while longer, catching our breath, necking, half sleeping. Eventually, he pulled out and disposed of the condom and came back to bed and pulled me against him.

"Stay a while," he said.

"I can't."

"Just a while."

I nestled against his chest and listened to his heartbeat slow down. I felt sore and satisfied and completely, utterly alive.

I made it home at ten forty-five. I showered and changed and was sitting on the couch reading when Callum came in at eleven.

"Hey," he said. "You're still up."

"I got into my book. Lost track of time."

He sat down next to me. He looked exhausted.

"Hard workout?" I asked.

"My legs were burning."

I laughed and leaned against him. He put his arm around me and sighed.

"I'm so glad to be home," he said. "I missed you."

"I missed you too."

He kissed the top of my head and we sat there in comfortable silence for a while.

"Hey," he said suddenly. "Did you hear anything weird earlier?"

My heart stopped. "What do you mean?"

"When I was coming up the stairs, Mrs. Patterson from below was in the hallway. She was going on about some noise earlier tonight. Said it sounded like someone was getting murdered upstairs."

I felt my face go hot. I stared at my book without seeing the words.

"I didn't hear anything," I said. "I had music on most of the night though."

"Weird. She was pretty upset about it. Said it went on for a while." He shook his head. "Must have been the guy in 3B. He's always got something going on up there."

I swallowed hard. "Probably."

"I should say something to him. It's not cool to be that loud when people are trying to sleep."

"Maybe he had company," I said. My voice came out strange, too high. "Maybe it was a one-time thing."

"Still. It's an old building. People should be considerate."

"Yeah." I turned the page of my book, even though I hadn't read a word. "Considerate."

He yawned and stretched. "I'm going to bed. You coming?"

"In a minute. I just want to finish this chapter."

He kissed my forehead and went to the bedroom. I sat there on the couch, my heart pounding, my face burning. I could hear Mrs. Patterson's voice in my head. It sounded like someone was getting murdered upstairs.

That was me. That was me screaming Deke's name. That was me, loud enough for the whole building to hear.

I should have been mortified. I should have been terrified. But sitting there in the dark living room, I felt something else, something that felt almost like pride.

I'd never been the kind of woman who made noise. I'd never been the kind of woman who lost control. I'd spent my whole life being quiet, being good, being invisible.

I guess not so much anymore.

The next morning, I ran into Mrs. Patterson in the stairwell.

She was a small woman in her seventies, with gray hair and sharp eyes and a permanent expression of disapproval. She looked at me as I came down the stairs, and I felt my face flush.

"Good morning," I said.

"Morning." She sniffed. "Did you hear that racket last night?"

"Callum mentioned something about it."

"It was disgraceful. Absolutely disgraceful. Some people have no shame." She leaned in closer, lowering her voice. "It was coming from the third floor. That young man with the motorcycle. I always knew he was trouble."

"I'm sure it won't happen again," I said.

"It better not. I have half a mind to call the landlord."

I nodded sympathetically and continued down the stairs, my face burning. When I got outside, I took a deep breath of cool autumn air and tried to calm my racing heart.

That young man with the motorcycle. I always knew he was trouble.

She had no idea. None of them had any idea. They thought they knew me. They thought I was the quiet one from 2B, the one who worked at the library, the one who kept to herself.

They had no idea who I became when I climbed those stairs.

I went up on Monday while Callum was at work. I told myself I was just going to say hello, just going to see him for a few minutes. I stayed for three hours and left with my legs shaking, my body wracked, and my voice hoarse.

I went up on Wednesday while Callum was at the gym. I told myself I would be quick. I wasn't quick at all.

I went up on Friday while Callum was at happy hour with his coworkers. I didn't bother telling myself anything anymore.

Each time was different. Each time we found new ways to drive each other crazy, new games to play, new boundaries to push. I was learning things about myself that I'd never known, discovering a capacity for pleasure and playfulness and nakedness that had been buried somewhere deep inside me all these years.

On Monday, we started on the couch and ended up on the floor, tangled in a heap of cushions and throw blankets. I was on top, riding him, when I decided to stop moving entirely. I just sat there, impaled on him, perfectly still, watching his face contort with frustration.

"Tiff," he said through gritted teeth.

"Yes?"

"Move."

"I don't think I will."

"Please."

"Hmm." I tapped my finger against my chin, pretending to consider.
"No."

He grabbed my hips and tried to thrust up into me, but I lifted myself just enough to stay out of reach. He groaned and fell back against the floor.

"You're evil," he said.

"You keep saying that."

"Because it keeps being true."

I clenched around him, just once, just a little squeeze, and his whole body jerked.

"Jesus Christ," he said.

"Just Tiff."

"You're enjoying this too much."

"I'm enjoying this exactly the right amount."

I stayed perfectly still for another minute, watching him squirm, watching the sweat bead on his forehead. His hands were gripping my hips

so hard I knew I'd have bruises tomorrow. I'd have to be careful about what I wore around Callum.

Finally, when I could see he was about to lose his mind, I started moving again. Slow at first, then faster, then so fast we were both gasping and crying out and the neighbors definitely heard everything then.

On Wednesday, he bent me over the kitchen counter and took me from behind, and I had to bite down on my hand to keep from screaming. It didn't work. I screamed anyway, into my palm, the sound muffled but not muffled enough.

"Shhh," he said, laughing against my neck.

"I can't, I can't help it."

He thrust harder and I cried out again, louder this time, and he didn't try to quiet me. He laughed against my shoulder and kept going, and we were both laughing and gasping at the same time. I knocked a bowl off the counter and it shattered on the floor and neither of us cared.

"You're going to destroy my apartment," he said.

"You're going to destroy me."

The kitchen was a mess when we finished. There was food on the counter from something he'd been heating earlier, and now it was all over my back, in my hair, on his hands. Broken ceramic scattered across the floor. A chair had been knocked over at some point. We came out of the bedroom, my face and neck and tits dripping with his come, and stood there surveying the damage, naked and sweating and grinning at each other like idiots.

"Worth it," he said.

"Completely."

On Friday, we made it a game.

"I bet I can make you cry out loud in under five minutes," he said.

"I bet you can't."

"What do I get if I win?"

"What do you want?"

He grinned that slow wicked grin that made my stomach flip. "Surprise me."

He won. It took three minutes.

Afterward, we lay on his bed catching our breath, and I punched him in the shoulder.

"You cheated," I said.

"How did I cheat?"

"You know exactly what you did."

He rolled onto his side and propped his head on his hand. "And I'll do it again."

I laughed and pushed him away, and he grabbed me and pulled me back, and we wrestled on the bed like kids, laughing and shoving and trying to pin each other down. He won that too, but only because he tickled me until I couldn't breathe.

"Uncle," I gasped. "Uncle, I give up."

"Say I'm the best."

"You're the worst."

"Wrong answer."

He tickled me again and I shrieked and flailed and somehow we ended up on the floor in a heap, both of us laughing so hard we couldn't breathe.

"You're insane," I said.

"You love it."

I did.

He got up and went to the kitchen, stepping over the mess we'd made earlier, and I heard the refrigerator open, heard bottles clinking. He came back with two beers and handed me one.

"To insanity," he said, raising his bottle.

"To cheating."

"I didn't cheat."

"You definitely cheated."

We clinked bottles and drank, and I felt something warm spread through my chest that had nothing to do with the beer. I was happy. I couldn't remember the last time I'd felt this way.

The complaints started piling up.

I didn't know at first, I only found out because Mrs. Patterson cornered me in the lobby on Saturday morning with fire in her eyes.

"It happened again," she said.

"What happened?"

"That noise. From the third floor." She shook her head. "I don't know what that young man is doing up there, but it's indecent. Absolutely indecent."

"I'm sorry to hear that," I said.

"I've written a letter to the landlord. Several of us have. Mrs. Chen from 1D. Mr. Kowalski from 1A. Even that nice couple on the second floor."

My blood ran cold. "Which couple?"

"I don't remember their names. The quiet ones. With all the bookshelves."

That was us. She meant Callum and me, clearly forgetting who I was. I vaguely remembered him mentioning something about the noise and about signing something, but I'd been distracted at the time and hadn't paid attention.

"It sounds pornographic," Mrs. Patterson continued, lowering her voice. "If you know what I mean. Screaming and carrying on. At all hours."

"I really wouldn't know."

"You must sleep like the dead. It's been going on all week."

I nodded and made my escape, my heart pounding so hard I could feel it in my throat. The whole building was complaining. Letters to the landlord. Multiple residents. And Callum had apparently signed something without me even noticing.

That night, I found the letter on his desk. A printed form, something official-looking, with a list of signatures at the bottom. "Noise Complaint: Unit 3B." Callum's signature was third from the top.

I stared at it for a long time. My boyfriend had signed a complaint about noises that were coming out of my throat.

The next time I went up, I told Deke about it.

"The whole building is complaining," I said. "They're writing letters to the landlord."

He was lying on the bed, naked, watching me pace around his room. He didn't look too concerned. I was undressing.

"Let them complain," he said.

"You could get evicted."

"I'm not going to get evicted."

"You might."

"Tiff." He propped himself up on his elbows. "Come here."

"I'm serious. This is a problem."

"It's only a problem if you make it one. Come here."

I stopped pacing and looked at him. He was grinning at me, relaxed and unconcerned, like none of this mattered.

"You don't care," I said.

"I can't control what the neighbors think. I can't control what they write to the landlord. The only thing I can control is what happens in this room."

He held out his hand. "So come here."

I took his hand. He pulled me onto the bed.

"Now," he said, rolling on top of me, "where were we?"

"We were talking about . . ."

He kissed me, and I forgot what we were talking about.

Chapter 12

I tried to be quieter the next few times, I really tried.

But it was impossible.

We'd start slow, careful, controlled. I'd tell myself I was going to keep my sounds contained, keep my voice low, keep everything under wraps. And it would work for a while, for a few minutes.

But then he'd do something with his hands or his mouth or his hips, and the sounds would start leaking out small at first, only little gasps, quiet moans. I'd catch them before they got too loud, swallow them back down.

But then the pleasure would build, and the gasps would get louder, and the moans would get longer, and by the time I was close to the edge I had no control left at all.

"That's it," he'd say, urging me on.

I'd let go and cry out and the walls would echo with it. I really couldn't help it.

One afternoon, we were in his bathroom because we'd started in the shower and hadn't bothered to move from there. I was sitting on the edge of the sink and he was between my legs and the mirror was fogging up behind me. I was trying, really trying, to be quiet, but then he hit that angle that made stars explode behind my eyes and I let out a cry that echoed off the tile.

"Jesus," I gasped when I could speak again. "That was too loud."

"That was too beautiful."

"Someone definitely heard that."

"Someone definitely did." He kissed my neck, my jaw, my lips.

We did it again and again, in the kitchen, against the wall in the hallway. By the time we were finished, I was hoarse and the place was wrecked and somewhere in the distance I could hear someone banging on pipes.

Another time, we were in his living room, on the floor, and I was on my hands and knees and he was behind me. I had my face pressed into a cushion, trying to muffle myself, but it wasn't working. Every thrust pushed a high pitched sound out of me, and by the end I was practically howling into the fabric.

"The cushion isn't helping," he observed afterward.

"I noticed."

"Maybe we should try something else."

"Like what?"

He thought about it. "I could gag you."

I threw the cushion at his head and wiped his come where it hung from my chin.

The complaints escalated.

A printed notice appeared in the lobby, passive-aggressive and official-looking, reminding residents that excessive noise was prohibited between the hours of 10 PM and 8 AM. Someone had underlined "excessive" three times in red pen.

Mrs. Chen stopped me in the stairwell to ask if I'd heard "those awful sounds" and whether I thought the landlord should "do something about that man on the third floor . . . and his guests."

"He seems nice enough," I said weakly.

"Nice men don't make noises like that," she said.

Mr. Kowalski from 1A started wearing earplugs and told anyone who would listen that he was considering breaking his lease.

The young couple from 2C, who I'd never spoken to before, knocked on our door one evening to ask if we'd we wanted to sign a petition.

"What kind of petition?" Callum asked.

"To get the guy in 3B evicted," the woman said. "It's been going on for weeks. It sounds like animals up there."

I stood behind Callum and felt my face burn.

"I'll sign," Callum said.

"This is getting ridiculous," he said, turning to me. "Someone needs to do something about this guy."

"Maybe it's not as bad as everyone says."

"Not as bad? Tiff, the whole building is complaining. People are talking about breaking their leases. It's affecting everyone."

I didn't say anything. I went to the kitchen and started washing dishes that were already clean.

"Are you okay?" Callum asked, coming up behind me. "You've been weird lately."

"I'm fine."

He rubbed my shoulders, his thumbs working at the knots in my muscles. He was so kind. So good. So completely unaware that his girlfriend was the one making those awful sounds, the one the whole building was complaining about, the one they wanted evicted.

"Come to bed," he said. "Get some rest."

"In a minute."

"Still," he said. "He's right above us but we never seem to hear it."

He kissed my cheek and went to the bedroom. I stood at the sink, my hands in the warm water, and stared at nothing.

The whole building knew. Not that it was me, but that something was happening in 3B, something loud, something indecent, something that had to stop.

I thought about all the times I'd tried and failed to be quiet. I thought about the sounds that came out of me when I was with Deke, sounds I couldn't control, sounds that seemed to come from somewhere deeper than my throat.

I couldn't stop them. I'd tried. Every time I tried to hold them in, they found a way out. It was like trying to hold back the tide.

Which meant I had to stop going up there. I had to stop seeing him. I had to end whatever this was before it destroyed everything.

I told myself I would do it tomorrow. I would go up there and tell him it was over. I would be strong.

I dried my hands and went to bed.

The next afternoon, I climbed the stairs to the third floor making sure nobody was in the hallways.

I knocked on his door. He opened it shirtless and grinning, and before I could say anything, he pulled me inside and kissed me against the wall.

"Wait," I said against his mouth. "I need to tell you something."

"Tell me later."

"It's important."

"Later."

He picked me up and carried me to the bedroom and threw me on the bed. I was laughing despite myself, and then he was on top of me and his mouth was everywhere and I forgot what I'd come to say.

Later, when we were lying tangled together in his sheets, sweating, breathing hard, wasted, I remembered.

"The landlord gave you a warning," I said.

"Hmm?"

"Mrs. Patterson told me. One more complaint and you're out."

He was tracing lazy patterns on my hip and didn't look up. "Then I guess we'll have to be more careful."

"Deke, I'm serious."

"I know you are." He finally looked at me. His eyes were warm and unconcerned. "It'll be fine, Tiff. These things always blow over."

"What if they don't?"

"Then I'll find another apartment." He shrugged. "I've moved before. I'll move again."

"Just like that? You don't care?"

"I care about a lot of things but this shit building isn't one of them." He leaned over and kissed me. "You worry too much."

"Someone has to."

"No, they don't." He rolled on top of me, pinning me down. "You know what I think?"

"What?"

"I think you need to stop worrying."

"I don't know how."

"Let me help."

He kissed his way down my body, and I felt the worry start to melt away, replaced by something warmer, something easier. By the time his mouth reached where I wanted it, I'd forgotten all about landlords and warnings and complaints.

When I cried out, I couldn't even try to be quiet.

At seven o'clock, Callum and I walked down to the laundry room together. Someone closed the door behind us.

Someone had arranged folding chairs in a rough semicircle, and most of them were already filled. Mrs. Patterson was in the front row, and she was clutching a notebook with her face set in grim purpose. Mrs. Chen sat beside her and nodded along to something Mrs. Patterson was saying. Mr. Kowalski was in the corner with his arms crossed, and he had dark circles under his eyes.

The Hendersons from 2C were there, the young couple who'd come to our door with that petition. A few people I didn't recognize sat scattered

among the chairs, and I assumed they were from the other places. In the back sat a tired-looking man in his fifties who held a clipboard, and I guessed he was the landlord.

Everyone spoke in hushed voices. They kept glancing toward the door and making sure no one was coming down from the third floor.

Callum found us two seats in the middle. I sat and folded my hands in my lap and tried to look like a concerned neighbor.

"Thank you all for coming," Mrs. Patterson said as she stood. She kept her voice low. "We all know why we're here, and we all know why we're keeping this quiet."

Murmurs of agreement rippled through the group.

"For the past several weeks, this building has been subjected to disturbances of an intimate nature." She said the word like it was coated in something foul. "They have been emanating from unit 3B."

"They're sexual in nature," Mr. Kowalski said flatly. "Let's not dance around it."

My face burned, and I studied my hands.

"Yes, well." Mrs. Patterson cleared her throat. "The point is that we need to discuss our options and present a united front." She nodded toward the landlord. "Mr. Briggs has already issued a warning."

"One more documented complaint and I can begin eviction proceedings," the landlord said.

"One more?" Mrs. Chen shot to her feet. "It should have been eviction after the first incident. What he does up there is indecent."

"It sounds like animals," someone muttered.

"It sounds worse than animals," Mrs. Patterson said. "I lived through the sixties, and I never heard anything like this."

Someone laughed nervously. I wanted to dissolve into the floor.

"Can you describe the disturbances?" the landlord asked, and his pen was ready. "It would help for documentation purposes."

"Describe them?" Mrs. Patterson looked appalled. "That's hardly appropriate."

"It helps build the case."

Silence fell over the room. Then Mr. Kowalski spoke.

"There's screaming," he said. "There's moaning. It goes on for extended periods, and it happens multiple times a day sometimes."

"It happens multiple times a day?" someone repeated.

"The walls are thin," Mrs. Henderson said. "We hear everything, and I mean everything."

"There's laughing too," her husband added. "That's somehow worse. It sounds like they're having the time of their lives while we're trying to live normal lives."

"The laughing is obscene," Mrs. Chen agreed. "It's so joyful and so unrestrained."

I was going to combust. I was going to burst into flames right here in this folding chair.

"Does anyone know who he has up there?" someone asked. "Has anyone seen her?"

Chapter 13

My heart stopped.

"I've tried to catch a glimpse," Mrs. Patterson said. "But she's sneaky, and she comes and goes when no one's around. I don't know how she's getting into the building or back out, I watch the front door like a hawk."

"Maybe it's a different woman each time," Mr. Kowalski suggested. "A man like that could have anyone up there."

"It's the same woman," Mrs. Henderson said with authority. "I can tell by the voice, and it's definitely the same one every time."

"What does she sound like?" someone asked.

I gripped the sides of my chair until my knuckles went white.

Mrs. Henderson considered the question. "She sounds enthusiastic, I can tell you that much. She sounds very enthusiastic."

"I would say she sounds unhinged," Mrs. Patterson said.

"I would say she sounds animalistic," Mrs. Chen added.

"She sounds pornographic," Mr. Kowalski said.

"She sounds like someone being murdered," someone said from the back. "But like someone who's enjoying it."

Uncomfortable laughter rippled through the room. I couldn't breathe.

Callum leaned over and whispered, "Can you believe this? What kind of person has no consideration for the people around them?"

"I don't know," I managed.

"I feel bad for the woman, whoever she is. She probably has no idea everyone can hear her."

"She probably doesn't."

"It must be humiliating. But so weird, too. We never hear it! It's never when we're home!"

I nodded because I couldn't speak.

Mrs. Patterson opened her notebook. "I've been keeping a log for documentation purposes."

Of course she had.

"On Tuesday the third at 2:47 PM, there was an incident that lasted seventeen minutes," she read. "On Wednesday the fourth at 11:30 AM, there was an incident that lasted twenty-three minutes. On Friday the sixth, there

were three separate incidents that began at 10 AM, 1:15 PM, and 4:30 PM, and they totaled approximately forty-five minutes combined."

I remembered that Friday. Callum had been at work. I'd told him I was going to deep clean the apartment. Instead, I'd spent the entire day in Deke's bed, and I only came down when it started getting dark. My legs had barely held me up on the stairs.

"That's forty-five minutes," someone said, and they sounded grudgingly impressed.

"It was spread across three incidents," Mrs. Patterson clarified. "There were breaks in between."

"That's still impressive stamina," somebody murmured.

"It's inconsiderate is what it is," Mrs. Patterson snapped. "Some of us are trying to watch our programs."

I bit the inside of my cheek until I tasted blood.

"Hey, you were home for most of those times," Callum murmured to me.

I shrugged, not trusting my voice. "Headphones? Music? Out shopping or walking?"

"What about the property damage?" Mrs. Chen asked. "Last week I heard glass breaking up there."

She was talking about the bowl I'd knocked off the counter when Deke fucked me too hard over his counter, jolting my body.

"I heard that too," Mr. Kowalski said. "I also hear furniture moving constantly."

"It's a miracle the ceiling hasn't collapsed," Mrs. Patterson said grimly.

The landlord scribbled on his clipboard. "This is very helpful and very detailed."

"What we want to know," Mrs. Henderson said, "is what you're going to do about it. You said one more complaint would be enough, so what qualifies as a complaint?"

"Any documented disturbance that occurs after the warning would qualify."

"Then you should document this meeting," Mrs. Patterson said. "You should document all our testimonies."

The landlord shifted in his seat. "Technically, I need to witness the disturbance myself, or I need to have a recording of it."

"You want us to make a recording?" Mrs. Chen looked horrified.

"I'm just explaining the legal requirements."

"This is absurd," Mr. Kowalski said. "The man is running a brothel and we need lawyers involved?"

"It's not a brothel," the landlord said wearily. "It appears to be just one woman."

"It's one very loud woman," Mrs. Patterson corrected.

"Whoever she is, she should be ashamed," Mrs. Chen said. "She carries on like that without any dignity."

"How does she get in and out, that's what I'm mystified by," the other one said again. "I watch the door like a hawk," she said to her neighbor.

I wanted to run. I wanted to vanish. Instead, I sat perfectly still while my face burned and my hands clenched.

Callum raised his hand.

"Yes?" Mrs. Patterson said.

"I think we should have compassion," Callum said. "I don't mean for him, because he's clearly inconsiderate. But we should have compassion for the woman. She might not know how thin the walls are, and she's probably mortified already. She'll definitely be mortified when she finds out."

"That's very charitable of you," Mrs. Patterson said. "But ignorance is no excuse."

"I'm just saying that when this comes out, we should remember she's a victim too. She's a victim of his carelessness. She might have no idea. Right Tiff?" he said to me.

A few people nodded. I wanted to scream.

"She should have some idea," Mrs. Chen said. "When you're screaming loud enough to wake the dead, you should know that people can hear you."

"Some people lose themselves in the moment," someone offered. "It happens to people."

"It doesn't happen to decent people," Mrs. Patterson said firmly.

The meeting continued for another half hour. They discussed noise ordinances and legal options and the possibility of soundproofing at the building's expense. They talked about police reports and city complaints and warning notices for 3B.

Through all of it, I sat and smiled and nodded. I made sympathetic sounds when Mrs. Patterson described her ruined naps. I shook my head when Mr. Kowalski mentioned his blood pressure. I agreed with Callum that something had to be done.

When the meeting finally ended, people clustered together and kept whispering. Mrs. Patterson collected signatures on her petition. The landlord promised that action would be taken. Everyone was united in their outrage.

Callum put his arm around me as we walked back upstairs.

"That was intense," he said.

"It was."

"I can't believe that guy exists. And whoever this woman is, she has to know by now what's happening. I'd like to hear it just once, I can't believe it's as bad as they're making it out to be. Can you?"

"Maybe she doesn't live here, so maybe she has no idea."

"That's possible, I suppose." He shook his head. "Poor thing. Can you imagine being her and finding out everyone heard you?"

"I can't imagine that."

"It would be mortifying. I would never show my face again if it were me."

We reached our door, and he unlocked it and we went inside.

"You seem tense."

"I'm just tired. That meeting was a lot to sit through."

"You should get some rest."

He kissed my forehead and went to shower. I heard the water start running.

I stood in the living room and looked at the ceiling. Deke was up there, just one floor above me. He was probably lying on his couch and had no idea that a dozen people had just spent an hour dissecting every sound I'd ever made in his apartment under him and riding him. .

I thought about going up and telling him everything. I thought about describing the secret meeting and the signatures and the log of every moan and cry that Mrs. Patterson had spoken about.

But I didn't go.

I went to bed and pretended to sleep, and stared at the ceiling until morning.

When I came down to go out, I heard voices in the lobby. Callum's voice and another voice I recognized immediately.

I froze on the landing between the second and first floors. I could see them through the gap in the railing. Callum was standing by the mailboxes

with his work bag over his shoulder, and Deke was checking his mail wearing sweatpants that hung low on his hips.

"Hey, man," Callum was saying. "You're the guy from 3B, right?"

"That's me." Deke's voice was easy and relaxed. "And you're from 2B."

"Yeah. Callum." He stuck out his hand and Deke shook it. "Listen, I don't want to be that guy, but we need to talk about the noise situation up there."

My heart stopped. I pressed myself against the wall and held my breath.

"Noise situation?" Deke made himself sound genuinely puzzled.

"Come on, man. The whole building knows. The screaming, the sounds. It's been going on for weeks. You got the notices."

"For weeks? You sure that's me?"

"Don't play dumb. People are losing sleep. They're talking about evicting you."

"That's too bad."

"That's all you have to say?" Callum's voice was getting tighter. "Look, I get it. You've got a girl up there, you're having fun. But there are other people in this building. We have to live here too."

"I hear you."

"Do you? Because it doesn't seem like you care."

There was a pause. I peeked around the corner and saw Deke leaning against the mailboxes, his arms crossed over his chest. He was smiling that easy smile of his, the one that made my stomach flip.

"I care about a lot of things," Deke said. "What the neighbors think of me and my lady isn't one of them."

"That's exactly the problem."

"Is it? Seems like the problem is thin walls."

"The problem is you having loud sex at all hours of the day and night."

Deke laughed. It was a warm, genuine laugh, and it made Callum's face go red.

"Something funny?" Callum asked.

"Not really. I just think it's interesting that everyone's so worked up about my own business."

"Worked up? They're losing their minds."

"Maybe Mrs. Patterson should try having some fun of her own."

"That's not, that's completely . . ." Callum sputtered. "You're unbelievable."

"So I've been told. You hear it yourself? This so-called noise?"

Callum sputtered some more and stayed silent.

"Didn't think so. Hey man, maybe it's not as bad as they say, maybe they're all just jealous, you know?"

I saw Callum's face from the side. He seemed to be mulling that one over. Because it was true, he strangely never heard a thing the whole time, though you'd think he would, living right below the said apartment.

I should have walked away. I should have gone back upstairs and waited for Callum to leave. But I couldn't move. I was frozen, watching my boyfriend confront my lover, listening to them talk about me without knowing I was standing ten feet away.

"Just try to keep it down," Callum said finally. "Have some consideration for the people around you. That's all I'm asking."

"I'll take it under advisement."

"And maybe warn your girlfriend that the whole building can hear her. She probably has no idea."

"You think so?"

"I'm sure of it. No woman would be that loud if she knew everyone was listening."

Deke smiled, and for a terrible moment I thought he was going to say something. I thought he was going to look up and see me on the stairs and everything would come crashing down.

But he just shrugged. "Maybe she doesn't care either."

"Then you're both inconsiderate."

"Maybe we are."

Callum shook his head in disgust and turned toward the door. I flattened myself against the wall, barely breathing, waiting for him to leave. The front door opened and closed.

I stayed frozen for another thirty seconds. Then I heard footsteps on the stairs coming up and Deke appeared on the landing below me.

He looked up and saw me and his face broke into that grin.

"Morning, quiet girl," he said and he laughed.

"You're terrible."

"I know."

"He's my, he's my . . ."

"I know who he is." He climbed the stairs until he was standing one step below me, which put us almost at eye level. "He seems nice. Very concerned about the neighbors."

"This isn't funny."

"It's a little funny."

"He could have figured it out."

"He didn't figure anything out. He thinks I've got some mystery woman up there making all that noise." His grin widened. "He has no idea the mystery woman lives right below me."

"Stop smiling."

"I can't help it."

He leaned in and kissed me, right there on the stairs where anyone could see. I pushed him away.

"Are you crazy?" I hissed. "Someone could come out."

"Let them."

"Deke."

"Fine, fine." He held up his hands in surrender. "I'll be good."

"You don't know how to be good."

"You're right. It's one of my many flaws." He started up the stairs toward his apartment. "You coming or what?"

"I can't. I have to go to work."

"Skip work."

"I can't skip work."

"Why not?"

"Because normal people have responsibilities."

He turned and looked at me from the top of the stairs. He was backlit by the window on the landing, and the morning sun outlined his shoulders and chest.

"Is that what you are?" he asked. "A normal person?"

I didn't answer.

"Tomorrow?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"You know."

He disappeared around the corner, and I heard his door open and close. I stood on the stairs another minute trying to slow my heartbeat. Then I went to work and shelved books and pretended to be normal.

That night, Callum and I were in bed. He'd been tired from work, stressed about things, but he'd reached for me the way he sometimes did when he really needed to.

I let him touch me. I closed my eyes and tried to focus on his familiar hands, his familiar weight, his familiar rhythm. But my mind kept drifting. I kept thinking about the stairs that morning, about Deke's grin, about the way he'd kissed me where anyone could see.

Callum moved on top of me and pushed inside me and I wrapped my legs around him and tried to be present. He moved slowly, gently, the way he always did.

And then something happened.

He shifted his angle and hit a spot that made my breath catch. It wasn't the same as with Deke, but it was something, a spark where there usually wasn't one.

And I let out a loud sound, very different from anything I usually did with Callum. Which was to say, not silence. It was a high-pitched sustained cry.

Chapter 14

He looked down at me, surprised. "Tiff?"

I covered my mouth and beaded out my eyes.

He moved again on me, and within a minute I made another sound, even louder this time.

"Tiff??"

"Don't stop," I whimpered, becoming lost in it.

He didn't stop. He moved faster and harder on me and I gripped his shoulders. The sounds kept coming, maybe not as loud or as sustained as I was with Deke, but louder than I'd ever been with Callum, moans and gasps and high cries that seemed to come from somewhere deep in my chest. Just like with Deke.

"God," Callum breathed. "Tiff, you're s, you're never this!"

"Keep going!" I cried.

He kept going. I closed my eyes and let myself feel it, let myself make the sounds that needed to come out. When I finally tipped over the edge, I cried out loud enough that Callum actually covered my mouth with his hand.

"Shh," he said, laughing. "The neighbors!"

I opened my eyes. His hand was over my mouth and he was smiling down at me, pleased with himself.

"Where did that come from?" he asked when he rolled off me and caught his breath and slid his condom off.

I couldn't answer.

He lay beside me, catching his breath. "That was different. That was really different."

"Good different?" I said meekly.

"Amazing different. I've never heard you make any sound before." He propped himself up on his elbow and looked at me. "What changed?"

"Nothing changed."

"Something changed. You were so loud. You were never loud before."

"I don't know. I just felt it more tonight?"

He was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "Maybe it's that woman up stairs. All the talk about her, everybody talking about her making so much

noise. You go all turned on, maybe.”

"Maybe?"

He kissed my forehead and rolled onto his back. "Yeah, maybe that's it," he said with a smile on his face. Within minutes, he was asleep.

But I lay awake, staring at the ceiling.

Something had changed alright, but it wasn't what Callum thought. It wasn't that I'd finally learned to let go with him, it was that I couldn't separate the two parts of myself anymore. The woman I became with Deke was bleeding into the woman I always was with Callum.

I'd learned how to make noise. I'd learned how to feel things in my body without hesitation or shame. And now I couldn't turn it off.

It happened again a few nights later.

We were on the couch watching TV and Callum started kissing my neck the way he did when he wanted something. I let him pull me into his lap. I let him undress me. I let him touch me the way Deke touched me, and I made the sounds I made with Deke, too, and Callum looked at me like he was seeing someone new.

"Jesus," he whispered. "Who are you and what have you done with my girlfriend?"

I didn't answer. I just kissed him harder.

And then I slid down to my knees between his legs. It was his turn to make a lot of noise, then, and when he pushed the table out of the way and took me on the floor, well, the neighbors were going to complain, weren't they.

Afterward, he held me close and stroked my hair.

"I don't know what's gotten into you lately," he said. "But I like it."

"Maybe like you said, the girl upstairs."

"You seem more alive." He kissed my temple. "Whatever it is, don't stop."

I closed my eyes and let him hold me.

I was becoming someone new. Someone who existed between two worlds, two beds, two lives. I couldn't keep them separate anymore. The Tiff who screamed in Deke's apartment was the same Tiff who lay in Callum's arms. They were merging, blending, becoming one person.

The next morning, Callum left for work with a spring in his step.

"I'll be home early tonight," he said, kissing me goodbye. "Maybe we can continue where we left off."

"Maybe."

He grinned and headed out the door.

I waited until I heard his footsteps on the stairs. Then I snuck up to the third floor.

Deke opened the door. "I heard you last night," he said. "I'm gonna lodge a complaint with the landlord!" He laughed and yanked me inside.

My face went hot. "What?"

"Through the floor. I heard you." He was grinning that wicked grin. "Sounds like someone's been practicing."

"That's not, I wasn't . . ."

"You were loud, quiet girl. Not as loud as you are with me, but loud enough." He leaned against the doorframe. "Does he know where you got that from?"

"Shut up!"

"Does he know who taught you how to let loose like that?"

"I said shut up!" I slapped him playfully.

He laughed and stepped back to let me past. My face burned.

"For the record," he said, closing the door behind me, "I don't mind. I think it's fucking hot."

"You think everything is hot."

"True." He came up behind me and wrapped his arms around my waist. "But especially this. Especially knowing you're taking what I taught you and using it."

"You didn't teach me anything."

"Didn't I?" His lips brushed against my ear. "You were so quiet when I met you. So careful. And now listen to you. Making noise through the floorboards pissing off a whole building."

"I hate you."

"No, you don't."

He was right. I didn't hate him. I didn't know what I felt anymore. Everything was tangled together, pleasure and guilt and fear and desire, and I couldn't separate any of it.

"Come to bed," he said.

I went.

This time, when I cried out, I didn't even try to be quiet. Let the whole building hear it. Let Mrs. Patterson write it in her notebook. Let the landlord evict Deke. Let Callum find out about who the mystery woman upstairs really was, and leave forthwith!

Who would ever guess it would turn out to be the quiet girl in 2B?

I turned the last page of the novel then turned it back and re-read the final page, letting the finish settle deeper into me.

I closed the cover and pressed my palm flat against it and let out a small harrumph of satisfied victory.

The apartment was quiet. The radiator clicked and hummed. Outside, the last light of autumn faded behind the buildings across the street and the streetlamp flickered on in its hesitant, apologetic way.

It was my favorite part of a day, when I felt most like myself, just before I came back down from a story and re-entered my own body. Time for tea, I said to no one.